

The background of the cover is a dramatic, painterly illustration. It depicts a man with dark hair and a beard, wearing a dark, wet t-shirt, floating on his back in a body of dark, turbulent water. His arms are outstretched. In his left hand, he holds a single, pale, trumpet-shaped flower. The water is dark blue and black, with numerous small, glowing orange and red flames or embers floating around. A large, bright orange and red sun or moon is partially submerged in the water, creating a large, shimmering reflection. In the upper right background, a dark, gothic-style building with a spire is visible, also reflected in the water. The overall mood is somber and mysterious.

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No. 110

CRUEL SUN, THE WATER SAID

CHEW Z

A ROYA PUBLICATION

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Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 110

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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SYNOPSIS

Lahaina sits on the dry side of Maui, between a green mountain and a blue sea. Long ago it was called Lele, and it was so full of running water that the whalers called it the Venice of the Pacific. Then the sugar planters turned the streams away to their fields. The streams stopped running. The king's pond was filled in and a ballpark was built on top of it. When the sugar left, the old cane fields above the town filled up with tall dry grass, and nobody cut it.

Kanoe cleans hotel rooms at a resort up the coast. She lives in her grandfather's plantation house above Front Street with her mother, Tūtū, who has never in seventy-nine years gone into the sea past her knees, and her son Keola, eight, who backflips off the harbor wall every afternoon.

Wes is a high-school swim coach from Ohio. He has come to Lahaina with his son Theo, nine, and with the ashes of his wife in a bag in his backpack, to give her to the sea where they were married. He has taught a thousand children to swim. He cannot teach his own son, who has been afraid of deep water since his mother got sick.

It is the first week of August 2023. A hurricane is passing far to the south. The weather service has raised a red flag. The wind is coming.

And in the gaps between the chapters, something older than the island has started to talk. It is very patient, and it is trying to be gentle, and it is speaking to someone.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book is fiction wrapped around something that happened.

On the morning of August 8, 2023, broken power lines in a high wind set fire to dry grass beside Lahainaluna Road, above the town of Lahaina on Maui. Firefighters put the fire out, and it was declared contained. That afternoon it came back to life in the same place and the wind drove it through the town. It killed one hundred and two people, most of them older people who could not run. It destroyed more than two thousand buildings and left something like ten thousand people with nowhere to live. Some of the people who survived it did so in the sea, behind the seawall on Front Street, for nine hours, with the town burning above them.

I have tried to keep the order of events, the weather and the broad shape of what went wrong faithful to the public record and to what survivors have said: the hurricane to the south and the high pressure to the north, the red flag warning, the power that was not turned off, the fire that was declared out, the sirens that were never sounded, the phones that did not work, the roads blocked by fallen poles and live wires, the hydrants that went dry, the request for stream water that waited on a desk, the people in the water, the surfers who paddled in through the reef in the dark for the children, the list of the missing, the hotels, the texts offering cash for burned land, and the tourists who came back while the search went on. Because this is a story and not a report, I have kept the numbers loose and the times approximate. Some things in the book, like the reports Wes reads at three in the morning, came out over the following year.

Everyone in this book is invented: Kanoë, Tūtū, Keola, Wes, Theo, Claire, Bully, the woman who sang on the hill. The few moments in the water that echo what real survivors described are told without names. Officials appear only by their titles, the Mayor and the Governor, and what they do here is only what was publicly reported. No company is named.

The suspicions in this book belong to its characters and to the water. The observations underneath them are real. I have tried to set the plausible ones beside the absurd ones, with enough of the facts that the reader can weigh them, and then to step back. The official investigations ruled the fire accidental. That answer and the questions around it can both be true.

The *nānā honua*, the angel's trumpet, is a real plant, poisonous in every part, and it does grow in Lahaina yards; it is not from Hawai'i, and it is not sacred. I have left Hawaiian gods and sacred beings out of this book on purpose. They are not mine to use. The one thing I have bent is the water's voice, and what Wes hears with his ears under. Everything else was lying in plain sight.

Hawaiian words in this book are written with the marks the language uses, the 'okina (a small mark for a catch in the voice, as in *Moku'ula*) and the kahakō (a line over a vowel that makes it long, as in *Tūtū*). The narrator from Ohio writes *Hawaii* the way he always has.

This book is for the people of Lahaina, whose town it is, and for the ones who are still on the list.

Chew Z

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Between the chapters of this story, someone else will speak.

*It is older than the town, and older than the island the town stands on,
and it has been inside every person in this book. It has been in their
tears and in their coffee and in the cup of their two hands at the edge of
the sea. It does not hurry. It remembers everything that has ever been
poured into it.*

*It will sound as though it is speaking to you. Listen anyway. It is
speaking to someone, all through one long night, and it is trying very
hard to be gentle.*

I. CRUEL SUN

1. The Water Was Here First

Kanoe

My name is Kanoe [kah-NOH-eh]. It means *the mist*, the soft rain that hangs on the mountain in the morning and never quite reaches the town. My mother picked it. She said she wanted me to remember what we were missing.

That's a Lahaina [lah-HY-nah] joke. You have to be from here to find it funny, and even then you don't laugh, you just kind of breathe out through your nose.

Let me tell you where we lived, so you can see it, because it isn't there anymore and somebody has to carry it.

Maui [MOW-ee] is an island shaped like a person bent over, head and body, two mountains joined by a low neck of land. The small mountain is on the west, and we call it Mauna Kahālāwai [MOW-nah kah-HAH-lah-WHY], *the mountain where the waters meet*. It is old and green and folded like a cloth somebody dropped, all sharp ridges and deep valleys, and the clouds sit on top of it nearly every day of the year. Up there it rains like it means it. Up there the moss is so thick on the rocks you can push your whole hand into it to the wrist. Down here, on the dry side, on the strip of flat land between the mountain and the sea, is Lahaina. Down here it hardly rains at all.

The old people say the name comes from a chief who was walking here in a drought a long time ago and said, *lā hainā* [LAH hy-NAH], *cruel sun*. Tourists like that story. They buy it on T-shirts. What they don't buy is the other half: that before it was Lahaina, this place was called Lele [LEH-leh], and Lele was not dry at all. Lele was green. Lele was so full of water they called it, later, when the ships came, the Venice of the Pacific.

Here is how that worked, and it is the most important thing I will ever tell you, so I'm going to say it simple.

The rain falls on the mountain. The rain runs down the valleys in streams, and the streams run all the way to the sea. Our people, a long time ago, cut the land into slices that followed the water. Each slice was called an ahupua'a [ah-hoo-poo-AH-ah]. Picture a piece of

pie with the point up on the mountain and the wide end in the ocean. Every family in that slice had a little of everything: forest at the top for wood and birds, the stream in the middle for taro [TAH-roh] fields (taro is a root we grow in flooded ponds and pound into food), the beach and the reef at the bottom for fish. Nobody owned the water. The water belonged to everybody in the slice, and everybody in the slice belonged to the water. You took what you needed and you let the rest run down to your neighbor, because your neighbor was your cousin and your cousin was going to feed you fish next week.

In our language the word for fresh water is wai [WHY]. The word for wealth is waiwai [why-WHY]. Water, water. You don't have to speak Hawaiian to understand what our ancestors were telling you with that. If you have water, you are rich. If somebody takes your water, they have taken everything, and they don't even have to touch your house.

Somebody took our water.

I'll tell you about that later. It's a long story and it has sugar in it.

. . .

We lived on a lane off Lahainaluna [lah-HY-nah-LOO-nah] Road, which runs straight up from the sea toward the old high school on the hill. *Mauka* [MOW-kah] of Front Street, we would say: toward the mountain. Here, nobody says north or south or east or west. You say *mauka*, toward the mountain, or *makai* [mah-KYE], toward the sea. Everything on this island is on its way from one to the other, and so are we.

The house was my grandfather's. He cut cane for the sugar plantation for twenty years, and in 1940 he took the little money he'd saved and bought that house, a plantation house, wood on short posts, a green tin roof, three bedrooms, one bathroom, a lanai [lah-NYE] (that's a porch) across the front where everybody's slippers (that's what we call flip-flops) piled up like a car crash. My mother was born in the back bedroom. I was born at the hospital in Wailuku [why-LOO-koo], the county town on the other side of the island, because my mother had some opinions about the back bedroom by then. My son, Keola [keh-OH-lah], was born in Wailuku

too. He was eight that summer. Three of us in that house: my mother, me, my boy. Three generations, one bathroom. You learn to be quick.

My mother is Tūtū [TOO-too]. That means *grandma*, and everybody called her that, the whole lane, the guy at the gas station, the pastor, me. I called her Tūtū too, mostly, except when I was scared or arguing with her, which was most days. She was seventy-nine. She was small and brown and round, with white hair she wore pulled back with a pencil stuck through it, and she had a voice that could reach the end of the lane without trying. She had worked thirty years at the bank in town and then twenty more doing nothing she would admit was work: feeding people, raising my son, minding the whole street's business from a plastic chair on the lanai.

In front of the house, by the gate, she grew a tree I have to tell you about, because it comes back. It was taller than the gate, thin-trunked, with big soft leaves, and it hung with flowers the size of my forearm. Long pale trumpets, cream and peach, that pointed straight down at the ground like they were ashamed of something. In the evening they gave off a smell, sweet and heavy, like somebody's perfume left in a closed car. Tourists stopped to take pictures of it. Tūtū called it *nānā honua* [NAH-nah hoh-NOO-ah]. That means *earth-gazing*, because of how the flowers look down. In English they call it angel's trumpet. It wasn't from here. Somebody brought it, a long time ago, like they brought everything, and it liked our dirt and stayed.

"Every bit of that tree is poison," Tūtū told Keola, the first day he could walk to the gate by himself. "The flowers, the leaves, the seeds. You eat it, you see things that aren't there, and then you see nothing at all for good. You understand?"

He was three. He understood the way three-year-olds understand. He stood under it for an hour with his mouth shut tight, looking up at the hanging flowers like they were going to come down and get him.

"Then why do you keep it?" I asked her.

“Because it’s pretty,” she said. “And because somebody has to remember what pretty things can do.”

That was Tūtū. She talked like that, half proverb and half insult, and you never knew which half was meant for you.

. . .

I worked housekeeping at a resort in Kā’anapali [kah-AH-nah-PAH-lee], about four miles up the coast. If you have been to Maui, you have probably stayed somewhere like it, and somebody like me cleaned your room, and you left her five dollars on the pillow, or you didn’t.

I’m not complaining. It was a good job. It had insurance. I had been there eleven years and I had a cart, my own cart, with my name taped on the handle, and I could turn over a king suite in twenty-two minutes on a good day, including the bathroom, including folding the end of the toilet paper into a little point so the guest feels like somebody cared.

Here is what I want you to see about Kā’anapali. The resorts sit on a long gold beach with the island of Lāna’i [lah-NAH-ee] floating across the water, and every morning before the guests wake up, the sprinklers come on. Hundreds of them. Thousands, maybe, if you count the golf course. They come up out of the grass with a little hiss and they turn and turn, throwing water in silver fans over lawns so green they look painted, and the light comes through the spray and makes small rainbows all over the property, and it is, honestly, one of the most beautiful things I have ever seen.

And then I would drive home, four miles, and look up.

Above the highway, all the way up the slope to where the rain begins, the land is brown. Not desert brown. Dead brown. The color of a paper bag. Grass up to your chest, dry as straw, crackling in the wind, mile after mile of it, right up to the edge of the town, right up to the back fences of the houses on the hill.

Green below. Brown above. The water knows which way it’s going. It always did. It’s just that somewhere along the way, somebody changed the address.

. . .

Let me tell you about my boy, and then I'll stop for a while.

Keola means *the life*. He was born early, and small, and the doctor said he'd be fine, and he was more than fine, he was the loudest baby on the ward. His father left for Las Vegas when Keola was two, because a cousin had a job there and the rent here had gone where rents go when everybody wants to live on your island except the people who were born on it. So many of us have moved to Las Vegas they call it the ninth island. That's a joke too. It isn't funny either.

That summer Keola was eight and had lost both his front teeth at once, so he whistled when he talked. He was skinny and brown and fast, with hair that stood up in the back no matter what you put on it. And he could swim. Oh, he could swim. He swam before he could walk properly. Tūtū used to take him down to the harbor when he was two and hold him in the shallow water by the boat ramp, and he would kick and laugh and put his face right in it, and come up spitting and laughing more. By six he was jumping off the harbor wall with the big kids. By eight he was doing backflips off it, which I had told him not to do, which he did every afternoon, which I knew about, because the whole harbor knew about it and the whole harbor called me.

He was not afraid of the ocean. That's what I'm saying. He was afraid of the angel's trumpet tree, and of the dark hallway at night, and of Tūtū when she used his whole name. But the sea he trusted the way you trust your own bed.

I want you to remember that. I am telling you now, at the start, so that later you will know that I told you.

2. The Channel

Wes

The first thing you notice, coming in, is that the water is the wrong color.

I say that as a man who has spent most of his life looking at water. I coach high-school swimming in a town in Ohio where the pool is the best-lit room in the county. I know chlorine blue, which is the blue

of a painted box. I know Lake Erie in March, which is the color of a filing cabinet. I thought I knew what water was supposed to look like, and then the plane came down over the channel between Maui and the islands across from it, and I put my hand flat on the window like a kid.

It isn't one color. That's what I want to say, and I am going to take a minute to say it right, because I have never been good with words and I need to be good with these.

Near the shore, where the water is shallow over white sand, it is the palest green you have ever seen, so pale it is almost not a color, the green of the inside of a cucumber or of light through a glass bottle. A little farther out, where the sand drops and the reef begins, it turns turquoise, but a turquoise so bright it looks lit from underneath, as if somebody has hidden lamps on the bottom. Then there are patches, dark shapes like spilled ink, and those are the reefs themselves, coral and rock under ten or twenty feet of water, and over the patches the water goes the color of a bruise, purple and brown. And then, all at once, as if someone drew a line with a ruler, the bottom falls away into the deep, and the water goes a blue I have no name for. Not navy. Navy is a uniform. This was a blue that went *down*. A blue with weight in it. Looking at it from the plane I had the feeling you get at the edge of a high diving board, the feeling in the backs of your knees.

Across the channel the island of Lāna'i sat low and long on the water like a sleeping animal, and behind it, farther off and fainter, the long dark ridge of Moloka'i [moh-loh-KAH-ee], and all of it, every island, wore a cloud on its top like a hat.

"Theo," I said. "Theo, look."

My son was asleep against my arm with his mouth open. He was nine. He had his mother's dark curls and her habit of sleeping with one hand in a fist under his chin like a boxer. I didn't wake him. I looked at the water for both of us, and I tried to remember what Claire had said, fourteen years earlier, on this same approach, when we were twenty-nine and thirty and it was the first time either of us had been anywhere.

She had said, *It looks like it's breathing.*

It did. It still did.

. . .

In the overhead bin above us, in my backpack, in a heavy plastic bag inside a cloth bag with a drawstring, were the ashes of my wife.

I'd like to say this the plain way, since there isn't a fancy way. Claire got sick in the spring of the year Theo turned seven. Ovarian cancer, which is a cancer that hides until it is everywhere. She fought it for a year and a half with a kind of furious good manners. She died the September before this trip, at home, in the hospital bed we'd put where the dining table used to be, on a Tuesday afternoon with the window open because she wanted to hear the high school band practicing across the field.

She had asked for one thing. Lahaina was where we got married, barefoot on the beach, and where we spent our honeymoon, and she wanted to go into the sea there, from a boat, out in the channel where we had seen the whales. "Not in Ohio," she said. "I've been cold in Ohio for forty-two years. Put me somewhere warm."

So I had. I had brought her. I had argued with an airline about it on the phone for forty minutes. The crematorium had given me her ashes in a square box made of some dark wood, very handsome and very heavy, and I had left the box on the dresser at home, because I could not carry her through an airport in something that looked like a jewelry case. I took her out. I put her in the bag. I put the bag in my backpack between my running shoes and Theo's inhaler. I am telling you this because I want you to know I am not a romantic man. I'm a practical man. I measure things. I think about weight.

My wife, all of her that was left, weighed a little over five pounds. I know because I put her on the kitchen scale. I'm not proud of it. I needed to know.

. . .

We were staying in a second-floor apartment on Front Street, which is the old main street of Lahaina, running along the water. I'd found it on one of the rental websites. The pictures showed a lanai with an ocean view, a kitchen with a pineapple-shaped cookie jar, two bedrooms, a ceiling fan with blades shaped like palm leaves. *Walk to everything! Steps from the seawall! Sunsets you'll never forget!*

When I opened the door it smelled of somebody else's cooking, years deep in the walls. There were pencil marks on the inside of the kitchen doorframe, painted over but still showing through the white, little lines with dates beside them, climbing up the wood. Somebody had measured their children here. Somebody had lived here for a long time before it became a place for people like me to sleep for a week.

I stood and looked at those marks longer than I should have. Theo dropped his bag on the floor and went straight to the lanai and stood at the railing, looking out across the street, across the low wall at the edge of the road, at the ocean.

It was right there. Thirty feet away. Front Street, then a seawall, black rocks piled against concrete, and then the water, slapping at the rocks, green-gold in the late sun, going out and out and out.

He stood there with both hands on the railing and didn't move.

"Pretty great, huh, bud?"

"It's really close," he said.

"Yeah."

"It's really, *really* close."

And I understood, the way you understand things about your child in your stomach before your head catches up, that he wasn't admiring it. He was keeping an eye on it.

. . .

I should explain about Theo and the water, because it's the thing I think about most, now, and because it was the great failure of my life before the other thing happened.

I am a swim coach. I've taught maybe a thousand children to swim. I can teach a scared six-year-old to put her face in the water in a single afternoon. I know the tricks. You blow bubbles. You count. You let them hold your hands and you never, ever let go until they tell you to. You make it a game. You make it boring, which is better than a game, because boring is the opposite of afraid.

Theo learned to swim when he was four, and he swam fine until he was seven. Then Claire got sick, and something happened inside him that I've never understood, and he stopped putting his face in. He'd go in the shallow end. He'd stand there. If the water came up past his chest his breathing changed, quick and high, a little catch at the top of every breath, and his eyes went somewhere far away. Deep water was worst. The bottom going away from under him. He said once, when I pushed him too hard at the Y, the YMCA pool back home, standing on the edge of the deep end in his trunks, shaking: "I can't see what's under it."

I said, "There's nothing under it, bud. It's a pool. It's twelve feet of nothing."

He said, "That's what I mean."

I teach other people's children. I couldn't teach mine. I brought him to the most beautiful water on Earth, and part of the reason I did it, a part I didn't say out loud even to myself, was that I thought maybe here, where his mother had been happy, the water would talk him round in a way I couldn't.

I was a practical man. I'm telling you I had stopped being one.

3. Green Below, Brown Above

Kanoe

Now I'll tell you about the sugar, because you can't understand what happened to us without it, and because nobody tells it on the T-shirts.

Go back two hundred years. Lahaina was the capital of the whole Hawaiian Kingdom then. Not Honolulu [hoh-noh-LOO-loo]. Here. Our kings and queens lived here, in the town of Lele, among the breadfruit trees, tall trees with big round fruit that tastes like bread

when you cook it. There's a phrase people still say, *Ka malu 'ulu o Lele* [kah MAH-loo OO-loo oh LEH-leh], *the shade of the breadfruit trees of Lele*. That's what this town was. Shade. Cool green shade over the paths, and streams running through it, and taro fields stepped down toward the sea, flooded with water, shining like mirrors.

In the middle of the town there was a big pond, fed by springs and streams, called Mokuhinia [moh-koo-hee-NEE-ah]. And in the middle of the pond there was a small island called Moku'ula [moh-koo-OO-lah]. It was the most sacred place in Lahaina. The king lived there, the third Kamehameha [kah-MAY-hah-MAY-hah], the one who ruled the longest, in the years when the whole world was arriving on his beach. His family was buried there. To reach him you crossed the water. Imagine that. A king on an island in a pond in a town full of streams, in the place we now call cruel sun.

Then the ships came. Whaling ships, from New England mostly, hundreds of them a year, anchored right out there in the channel where you see the snorkel boats now. That was the 1820s through the 1860s. The sailors came ashore for water and food and the things sailors come ashore for, and the town filled up with grog shops, which were the sailors' bars, and fights and missionaries, all at the same time, and they did not like each other. That's a whole other story. The missionaries built churches. The sailors once fired a cannon at a missionary's house. Lahaina was the wild west, except it was the wild middle of the ocean.

The court moved to Honolulu in the 1840s. The whales got scarce, because the whalers had killed most of them. And then the sugar came.

Sugar cane is a tall grass. It is sweet, and it is thirsty, more thirsty than you can imagine. To grow a single pound of sugar you need around a ton of water. A ton. So the men who started the plantations here, and there were a few big companies that ended up owning most of West Maui, they did what you'd do if you needed a ton of water for every pound of sugar and you had money and the law was on your side. They went up the valleys and they dug ditches and tunnels into the mountain, and they caught the streams up high, and they turned them. They sent the water sideways along the

slope, mile after mile, in ditches and flumes, which are wooden troughs on legs, to their fields.

The streams that used to run through Lahaina to the sea stopped running.

I don't mean all at once. I don't mean every drop. I mean that by the time my grandfather was a boy, the stream beds through town were dry most of the year, just rocks and weeds with a trickle in them after a big rain. The taro fields died. The springs that fed the royal pond got weak. The pond turned stagnant. Mosquitoes. Smell. And in the early part of the last century the county filled it in. They filled in the king's pond with dirt and they put a baseball field on top of the sacred island.

It's still there. A ballpark, with a dusty diamond and a chain-link backstop. Under the infield, under the pitcher's mound, is Moku'ula. You can go see. People are working to dig it back out. They have been working on it my whole life. It's slow, digging up a king.

...

Everybody called the plantation the mill, after the building where the cane was crushed, and it ran in Lahaina for more than a hundred years. My grandfather worked there. Then my mother's brothers. The mill whistle blew at shift change, and you could hear it all over town, and people set their clocks by it. Tūtū said when she was a girl the air at harvest smelled like burnt caramel, because before they cut the cane they burned the fields to clear the leaves, and the smoke came down over Lahaina sweet and black, and ash fell on the laundry. Black snow, they called it. *Maui snow*. The kids would run out and try to catch it on their tongues.

The mill closed in 1999. Sugar was cheaper to grow somewhere else, where the workers cost less. The fields went quiet. Nobody farmed them. And the plantation land, all those thousands of acres above the town, where the cane had been, filled up with grass.

Not our grass. Grass from Africa. Guinea grass, buffel grass, the kind of grass ranchers brought in a long time ago to feed cattle because it grows fast and doesn't need much. It loves it here. It grows six feet tall in the wet months, and then it dries, and it stands

there all summer like paper. Nobody grazes it. Nobody cuts it. It just stands there on the slope above Lahaina, mile after mile, right up to the fences, holding its breath.

When I was a kid, the mountain behind town was green with cane. When I was a woman it was gold with grass. When I was forty it was the color of a paper bag, and everybody on our lane knew what that color meant, and so did the fire department, and so did the people who make the laws, because it had already happened once.

. . .

August 2018. Five years before. There was a hurricane passing the island, Hurricane Lane, far out to sea, and it brought wind, big gusting wind that came down off the mountain, and a fire started up in the grass behind town, near Kaua'ula [kow-ah-OO-lah] Valley, and the wind pushed it down the hill into the houses.

It burned twenty-one homes. Twenty-one families. I knew three of them. We stood on the corner and watched the smoke go up from Kaua'ula, and Tūtū held Keola, who was three, and he said, "Is that a volcano?" and she said, "No, baby. That's just grass."

After that there were meetings. People came from the county and the state, and somebody had slides, and they talked about fire breaks, which are cleared strips a fire can't cross, and fuel, and cutting back the grass, and the dry grass on the old plantation land, and everybody nodded. A few things got done. Not enough things. You know how it is. The grass grew back by the next summer, taller.

"Water," Tūtū said, walking home from one of those meetings, leaning on my arm in the dark. "They don't need a meeting. They need to give back the water."

I said, "Mom, it's not that simple."

She stopped walking and looked at me. She did that, when she was about to be right.

"It was simple for a thousand years," she said. "It got complicated when somebody started making money from it."

4. The Boy Who Won't Go Under

Wes

On Friday I took Theo to the beach just south of town where the water is calm behind the reef. It's a good beach for teaching. White sand, a gentle slope, water as clear as gin and warm as a bath. Little yellow fish, bright as lemon peel, nosing around your ankles. A sea turtle came in once while we were there, a big one, his shell the size of a car tire, and he cruised through the shallows ten feet from us and put his old wise face up out of the water and breathed out with a sound like a tired man sitting down, and went on.

Theo watched the turtle with his whole body. He loved it. He loved it from where he was, which was standing in water up to his knees.

"You want to swim out and see him?"

"No."

"I'll be right next to you."

"No."

"We could just put our faces in. Just for a second. With the goggles. You'd see all the fish."

"I can see the fish from here."

I know how to do this. I tell parents all the time: don't push, don't bribe, don't make a fuss. Let the water be boring. So I let it be boring. I swam around in the shallows doing nothing. I lay on my back and floated, which is the thing I love most in the world, lying flat on the water with my ears under, hearing nothing but the click and hiss of the sea, looking up at a sky so big and blue it seemed to be coming down to meet me. Floating is the first thing I teach. Lie back, put your ears in, give the water your weight, it'll give it back. It's the first skill and it's the last one. A person who can float is very hard to drown.

I looked over and Theo was sitting on the sand at the water's edge with his knees pulled up, watching me float, with an expression I'd seen on his face only once before, in the doorway of the room where his mother was dying. It was the look of someone keeping watch.

I stood up and went in to him.

"Hey, bud."

"Hey."

"You want to go get shave ice?" Shave ice is ice shaved as fine as snow, with sweet syrup poured on top. Theo would walk a mile for it.

"Yeah."

We didn't talk about it. We never talked about it. That was a mistake. I made a lot of them. That one I'd take back first.

. . .

In the late afternoon we walked up Front Street to the banyan tree.

You need to see this tree, so I'll try. It stands in a square in the middle of town by the old courthouse, and it isn't a tree so much as a neighborhood. It was planted in 1873, I read on a plaque, a little sapling eight feet tall brought from India by the town sheriff to mark the fiftieth anniversary of the first missionaries arriving in Lahaina. A banyan grows strangely. It sends roots down out of its branches, thin as string at first, hanging in the air like hair, and when they touch the ground they take hold and thicken and become new trunks, so the tree walks outward, slowly, in every direction, holding itself up as it goes.

By the time we saw it, this one had something like sixteen trunks and covered most of the square. It was the biggest tree I'd ever been under. Its branches spread over the whole square on great gray arms held up by the trunks like a roof on pillars, and under it the light was green and dim and the air was ten degrees cooler, and there were benches and old men playing cards and kids running in and out between the trunks, and hundreds of birds, little brown mynahs, quarreling in the leaves with a sound like an argument in a crowded restaurant.

Theo walked in under it and looked up and said, "Whoa." Which is what you say.

We sat on a bench. I bought him a mango smoothie. He drank it with both hands and I watched a man in his eighties at the next bench feed crumbs to a pigeon with enormous dignity, one crumb at a time, like he was dealing cards.

"Your mom and I sat here," I said. "Right here. On our honeymoon."

"On this bench?"

"Maybe. One of them. They all look the same."

He looked at the bench as if it might have changed since then.

"Did she like it?"

"She loved it. She said it was like a church that grew itself."

He thought about that for a while. Then he said, "Are we still doing the boat on Tuesday?"

"That's the plan."

The plan was this: on Tuesday morning a small charter boat would take us out into the channel, two miles off, where the water was deep, and I would open the bag and give Claire to the sea. I had paid for it in advance. It was the one thing on the calendar. The rest of the week was supposed to be just us, being here, the way she wanted.

"Will it be deep?" Theo said.

"Pretty deep."

"How deep?"

I could have lied. I've thought about that a lot. "Couple hundred feet out there, maybe."

He didn't say anything. He put the straw back in his mouth and drank until it rattled at the bottom of the cup.

. . .

On the way back we cut down to the harbor. The small boat harbor in Lahaina is right in the middle of town, a square of calm water held in by a stone breakwater, full of fishing boats and charter boats and sailboats with their masts clicking in the wind like a hundred metronomes. At the end of the breakwater there's a wall, maybe ten feet above the water, and that afternoon there was a gang of local kids on it, eight or ten of them, brown and skinny and shining wet, taking turns jumping off.

Not just jumping. Cannonballs. Spins. A big kid of maybe fourteen did a front flip with a scream that echoed off the boats. Then a little one stepped up. Couldn't have been more than eight, all knees and elbows, his hair standing straight up at the back like a duck's tail. He looked over his shoulder at the bigger kids to make sure they were watching. They were. He bent his knees, swung his arms, and threw himself backward off the wall, head over heels, a full backflip, and went into the water feet first with hardly a splash.

The big kids went wild. Theo, next to me, grabbed my arm so hard it hurt.

The little one came up laughing, spat out a mouthful of the harbor, and swam back to the ladder like a seal, quick and easy, his face in the water every stroke, not bothering to look where he was going because he didn't need to. He climbed up, dripping, and walked right past us on his way back to the wall. He was missing both his front teeth. He saw Theo staring and grinned at him, a big gappy grin.

"Your boy no like swim, Uncle?" he said to me. It came out with a whistle through the gap.

I didn't understand right away. "Sorry?"

"He scared?" The kid pointed at Theo, not unkindly. "Water's nice. Come." He pointed down at the harbor. "Warm. Like one bath."

Theo shook his head, a small, fast shake.

The kid shrugged, the way kids do, *your loss*, and ran back to the wall and jumped again.

"Why did he call you Uncle?" Theo asked me, on the walk home.

I didn't know. I found out later that it's what kids here call any grown man, any grown man at all, a stranger, the mailman, a tourist from Ohio. Uncle. Auntie. Everybody is somebody's family. It's a courtesy. It's also a statement about how the world is supposed to work.

I didn't know that then. I just said, "I guess it's a nice thing."

"I liked him," Theo said.

"Yeah?"

“He wasn’t scared of anything.”

5. Red Flag

Kanoe

That week the wind started talking about something.

You learn the wind here the way you learn a person’s moods. Most days the trade winds come from the northeast, steady and cool, pushing the clouds onto the mountain where they drop their rain, and then slide down our side warm and dry. That’s normal. That’s the island breathing. But that week, at the start of August, there was a hurricane far to the south, a big one, called Dora. It never came near us. It passed hundreds of miles away, way down under the island, going west. And at the same time there was a big area of high pressure sitting far up to the north.

I’m not a scientist. Here’s how my mother explained it, and it’s good enough. “When you have a big push up there and a big pull down there,” she said, holding up one fist high and one fist low, “the wind runs between them like water downhill. And we’re in the way.”

On Monday, the seventh, the weather people put out a warning. A red flag warning, they call it. That’s the warning they give when it’s dry and windy and any spark will run. They said the winds would be bad Monday night and Tuesday. Gusts of sixty miles an hour, they said. Maybe more on the slopes. They said to secure loose objects. They said the humidity was low, which means the air was dry as paper. They said, in the gentle way they say it, *any fires that develop will likely spread rapidly.*

I read it at work on my phone during my lunch break, sitting on an upside-down bucket behind the laundry. Then I put my phone in my pocket and went back to work. That’s what you do. I had nine more rooms.

. . .

By afternoon you could feel it. The palms in the resort were bending over, all their fronds streaming one way like hair in front of a fan, and the sound they made was a long dry rush, like a crowd going *shhhh*. The pool attendants were running around collecting towels before they blew into the ocean. A beach umbrella came loose and went cartwheeling down the lawn like a drunk on a bicycle, and three of the boys from the activities desk chased it, laughing.

The sea was white. Usually from the resort the channel is blue and flat, Lānaʻi sitting on it like a plate on a table. That afternoon the whole channel was scratched with whitecaps, thousands of them, as far as you could see, and the wind tore the tops off the waves and blew them sideways in little ghosts of spray.

The sprinklers came on at five. I watched the water fly out of them and the wind catch it and carry it, every drop, sideways off the lawn and away into nothing before it touched the grass.

. . .

I got home at six. Tūtū was on the lanai in her plastic chair with a wet towel round her neck. Keola was in the yard with a soccer ball, kicking it against the wall of the house over and over, *bam, bam, bam*, which was his way of saying he was bored and the wind was making him crazy, which it makes everybody.

"Stop that," Tūtū said, without looking at him. He stopped. He started again a minute later. She didn't say anything that time.

The angel's trumpet was thrashing by the gate. The wind had torn off a lot of the flowers and they were lying in the dirt and on the walk, pale and bruised. The smell was everywhere, stronger than I'd ever smelled it, that thick sweet perfume, all of it shaken loose at once and blowing up onto the lanai.

"Smells like a funeral," I said.

"Smells like a party," Tūtū said. "Depends who's invited."

I sat down on the step below her and she put her hand on my head, the way she used to when I was little. Her hand was cool from the wet towel.

"The wind," she said, "is going to bring the power lines down tonight."

"Probably."

"You charge your phone?"

"Yes, Mom."

"Charge it again."

. . .

Here is a thing about my mother that I didn't know I would need to tell anybody, until I needed to.

That night she told Keola a story at bedtime. She did it most nights. He was eight and pretended to be too old for it, and he still lay there in the dark with his eyes open waiting for her to start. I was in the kitchen doing dishes by the light of the stove clock, and through the open door I could hear her voice going low and steady, the voice she saved for him.

She told him about the water. She did that a lot. She told him about the streams that used to run through town to the sea, and the taro fields, and the king on his island in the pond. She told him how the king, when he was small, younger than Keola, used to swim across to his island instead of taking the canoe, because he liked to arrive wet. She told him how the streams, before they were turned, would come down from the mountain after a rain so loud you could hear them in your sleep, and in the morning the whole town would wake up to the sound of water running, *everywhere*, like the town itself was laughing.

"Where did the water go, Tūtū?" he asked her. He had heard the story a hundred times. He always asked.

"Same place it always goes," she said. "Down. To the sea. The water always goes home. They can turn it, they can put it in a pipe, they can sell it, but in the end, every drop, every single drop, it comes home to the ocean. And the ocean remembers every drop that ever came. Every one. That's why it's salty. It's all the tears and all the rivers and all the rain that ever was, and it keeps them all. It doesn't forget anything."

"Does it remember me?"

"You," she said, "it knows by name."

I stood at the sink with my hands in the dishwater, not washing anything. Outside, the wind was getting louder. The tin roof was rattling at one corner where a nail had worked loose years ago and nobody had fixed it.

"Night, Tūtū."

"Good night, my life."

She called him that. *My life*. It's what his name means. She was the only one who said it in English.

6. The Night the Wind Came

Wes

The power went out at about ten.

I was lying in bed in the dark in the back bedroom, listening. The wind had been building all evening, and by ten it wasn't wind anymore, it was weather. It came off the mountain behind town in long screaming gusts that shook the whole building, and between the gusts there were pauses, a second or two of strange quiet, and then the next one would hit, harder, and something outside would bang and clatter down the street. Somebody's trash can. Somebody's patio chair. A palm frond the size of a canoe paddle hit our sliding door with a crack like a gunshot and I sat straight up in bed with my heart going.

Then the ceiling fan, which had been turning slowly over my head, slowed. Wound down. Stopped. The little green light on the smoke detector went out. The refrigerator in the kitchen gave a last shudder and fell silent, and in that silence I realized how much I'd been hearing it.

I got up and went out to the living room and looked through the sliding door. Front Street was black. The whole town was black. No street lamps, no windows, no neon from the bars up the street. Just the wind and, above it, a sky so full of stars it looked spilled. I'd never seen so many. Ohio has a stingy sky. This one had been opened like a sack of sugar and poured out from edge to edge, the

Milky Way a pale smoke right across the middle, and the stars weren't still, they were trembling, every one of them, the way stars do when the air is moving fast.

Under the stars the sea was making a sound I hadn't heard it make before. Not the soft slap and suck of the afternoon. A deep, steady roar, the waves coming in hard against the seawall across the street, *boom* and then a long rattling hiss as the water fell back through the rocks, *boom*, hiss, *boom*. It sounded like something very big breathing in its sleep.

I stood at the glass and looked at the dark water I couldn't see, only hear, and I thought: Claire would have loved this. She liked storms. She'd stand on the back porch in Ohio in thunderstorms with a beer, getting rained on, while I stood in the doorway asking her to please come in before she got struck by lightning.

The bag of her was on the dresser in the bedroom. I'd taken it out of the backpack that night. I don't know why. I think I wanted her in the room.

. . .

After a while I went back to bed. At some point, I heard Theo's door open.

He came down the little hall in the dark in his pajamas and stood in my doorway. I couldn't see his face. Just his shape, small and thin, and the white of his T-shirt.

"Dad."

"Hey, bud. Just the wind. Power's out. It's okay."

"It's loud."

"I know. Want to come in?"

He came in. He climbed up into the big bed on Claire's side, which was what we called the left side of any bed, still, even hotel beds. He hadn't slept in my bed since the first month after she died. He lay down with his back against me, and I put my arm over him, and I could feel his heart going like a bird's.

The building shook. Something heavy rolled down Front Street outside, clanging.

"Dad?"

"Yeah."

"Is the ocean going to come in?"

"No, bud. It's just wind. The ocean's staying where it is."

"How do you know?"

I didn't know. I said, "Because the wall's there. That's what the wall's for. To keep the ocean on its side."

He was quiet for a while. I thought he'd fallen asleep. Then he said, so quietly I almost didn't hear him over the wind:

"Is Mom going in tomorrow?"

I had forgotten. That's the truth. With the wind and the dark I had completely forgotten that tomorrow, Tuesday, was the boat.

"If the boat can go out," I said. "If the wind's this bad, maybe not. We'll see in the morning."

"Okay." A pause. "Dad?"

"Yeah."

"Will she be scared? In the deep part?"

I lay there with my arm around my son, in the dark, in a stranger's apartment with the marks of a stranger's children on the doorframe, with my wife in a bag on the dresser, and I didn't have an answer. I'm a coach. I'm supposed to always have an answer. Bend your knees. Tuck your chin. Breathe on every third stroke.

"No," I said. "She won't be scared. She'll be warm. That's what she wanted. She was always cold."

"Okay."

"Go to sleep, bud."

He did, eventually. I didn't. I lay awake listening to the wind try to take the roof off, and to the sea breathing against the wall, and every time a gust came I tightened my arm round him a little without meaning to, the way you grip the edge of something when you lose your footing.

Around four I must have dozed, because I dreamed. I won't tell you most of it. I'll tell you only that in the dream I was floating on my back in very warm, very dark water, with my ears under, and I could hear, through the water, somebody talking. A woman's voice. Low and steady. Telling a story to someone. I couldn't make out the words. I just knew from the sound of it that it was a story you tell a child at night, to keep them from being afraid of the dark.

Said at the Reef

You are afraid of me. That's all right. Most of your kind are, at first. You come from the land, and the land is a floor, and I am not a floor. I am the opposite of a floor. I am the place where the floor goes away.

But listen. Lie still a moment and let me tell you where you are, because a thing is less frightening once you know its name.

You are on the west side of an island that a fire built. Long ago, so long that the number would mean nothing to you, the earth under this ocean opened a wound that never closed, and melted rock came up through it, and through me, hissing, boiling me as it rose, and it cooled into mountains. I was there. I held it while it hardened. I have held every island in this chain from the day it came up out of the dark, and I will hold each one when it goes back down, because they all go back down. That is a secret about islands. They are only visiting.

The rain made the island green. That is my doing too. I rise off the sea as warm breath, invisible, and the trade wind carries me to the mountain, and the mountain pushes me up into the cold, and I turn back into myself and fall. On top of the mountain behind this town it rains more than in almost any place in the world. Up there I live in the moss. I live in the ferns, in the long silver threads of waterfalls that hang off the cliffs like rope. Then I gather myself in the valleys and I run down. That is all I have ever wanted to do. Run down. Come home.

Before your kind of people came, the people who were here understood that. They made their lives in the shape of my running. They cut their land in slices that followed my streams, from the

cloud to the reef, so that every family could stand somewhere along my path and dip their hands in me. They grew their taro in pools of me, terrace after terrace stepping down the slope, each one spilling into the next, the way you might pass a full cup down a table. They let me reach the sea. That was the rule, and it was the only rule that mattered: whatever you take, let some of it get home.

Look down. You can see it from here. The reef.

It is alive, all of it. What looks like stone is a city of tiny animals, each one smaller than a grain of rice, each one building itself a little cup of white stone out of me, out of what I carry, and living in the cup, and dying in it, and leaving it for the next one to build on. A thousand years of that and you have a reef. Ten thousand and you have this. Green and gold and violet, built like a cathedral by creatures that never knew they were building anything. Fish move through it in clouds. Yellow ones, bright as a lemon cut open. Blue ones that turn silver when they turn. A long thin one, like a needle, that hangs at the surface and watches. In the winter the whales come down from the cold north and sing in this channel, and the songs carry through me for miles, and the people on the shore put their heads under me to hear, and for a little while they are quiet.

Some of you give me your weight the way a man hands over a sleeping child. Not many. Most of you hold yourselves up. You stiffen. You keep your face out of me and your eyes on the bottom, and when the bottom goes away you feel it in your knees and your stomach, and you go back to where you can stand. I don't blame you. Most of you have lost a floor once already, somewhere in your life, and have been standing very carefully ever since, testing every step.

I understand that. I lost my floor too, in a way. I'll tell you about it. Not yet. There's time. Tonight there's nothing but time.

For now I want you only to know this one thing. Everything that has ever come down to me, I've kept. Every drop of rain. Every river. Every tear anybody ever cried on this beach. They are all still here, in me, not lost, only mixed. Somewhere in this channel, right now, is the water that once ran through the king's pond. Somewhere is the sweat of the men who cut the cane. Somewhere is the rain that fell

on this island the day it rose. I don't forget. I can't. It isn't in me to forget.

That's what the old woman on the hill told her grandson every night. She was right. She usually was.

Lie still. You're all right. I've got you.

II. DECLARED CONTAINED

7. Contained

Kanoe

The alarm on my phone went at five-fifteen and the phone was the only light in the house.

The power was still out. It had gone out around ten the night before and it had not come back. The wind hadn't stopped all night. It had found every gap in the old house, every loose board, every crack around the window frames, and it had whistled through them in different notes like a broken church organ. The loose corner of the tin roof had banged until two in the morning and then, suddenly, stopped, which meant either the nail had gone back in by itself or the piece of roof had gone to Lāna'i.

I dressed in the dark. In the kitchen I could hear Tūtū breathing from the back bedroom, a little whistle at the end of every breath, the way she did when she was in deep. I didn't wake her. I left a note on the counter under the rice cooker, which was where we left notes. *No power. Went work. Charge phone in car if you need. Love you.* I looked in on Keola. He was asleep sideways across his bed with one foot hanging off the edge and his mouth open, and the wind was pushing the curtain in over him, out, in, out, like the room was breathing.

I almost didn't go to work. I want to say that, because later I counted every almost. I stood in the doorway of his room and thought: it's a bad day, the power's out, no school, just stay home. Then I thought about my nine rooms, and about my supervisor, who was a nice man who was not nice about attendance. And the resort would have generators. Somebody had to be there for the guests, who would be hot and angry and wanting coffee.

So I went. I kissed the top of my boy's head and he didn't wake up, and I went out past the angel's trumpet, whose flowers were all over the ground now, smashed and brown and still smelling, and I got in the car and drove up the coast in the dark, under trees that were bending nearly to the road.

The last thing I saw of my house, the way it was, was in the rear-view mirror: just a dark shape, and the tree thrashing by the

gate, and the long brown slope of the mountain behind it, black against a sky that was starting to go gray.

. . .

The resort was in chaos, the polite kind. The generators were running the kitchens and the front desk and some of the hallway lights, but not the air conditioning in the rooms, and not the elevators in the tower. Guests were coming down the stairs in their bathrobes looking for coffee and an explanation. I gave them neither. I was a housekeeper. I smiled and said, "So sorry, ma'am, I don't know. Front desk might know," and I went up the stairs with my cart, which I had to leave at the bottom, carrying my towels and sheets up six flights in a laundry bag on my back like Santa Claus.

At ten to seven my phone buzzed in my pocket. A text from my cousin, who lived two streets over from us.

fire up lahainaluna by the school. firemen there. u ok?

I stopped on the stairs between the fourth and fifth floors with the bag on my back and called home. It rang and rang. I called again. Tūtū answered on the fifth ring, sounding cross.

"What?"

"Mom. There's a fire up the road."

"I know. I can see it. I'm standing in the yard."

"Is it close?"

"It's up by the school. The grass is burning. Fire trucks are there, three, four. Lot of smoke. Lot of wind." I could hear the wind in the phone, a roar like the phone was pressed against a seashell. "Police came down the lane, said maybe go, just in case."

"Then go! Take Keola and go!"

"I'm going, I'm going. Don't shout at me. Auntie Rose is picking us up. We'll go to her place by the harbor till it's done."

Auntie Rose was not my aunt. Auntie Rose was the woman who'd lived across the lane for forty years and then moved down near the harbor when her husband died. Everybody's family, I told you.

"Call me when you're there."

"I'll call you, I'll call you. Go do your work. Bye. Love you." And she hung up, because Tūtū never in her life stayed on a phone call one second longer than she had to. She thought phones were rude. She said if you wanted to tell somebody you loved them, you should go stand in front of them.

...

She called back at eight-twenty. They were at Auntie Rose's. Keola was eating cereal with no milk, because there was no cold milk, there was no cold anything in the whole town. The smoke was going the other way, out over the hills, she said, the wind pushing it. And then a little before ten my cousin texted again.

they saying contained

And a little after that I saw it on my phone too, the county had put it out, the fire in Lahaina was contained. Contained means the firefighters have got a line around it, a ring of dug-out dirt and wet ground, so it can't get out and spread. Later they would say it was out. Fully out. I read the word, *contained*, standing in a guest's bathroom with a toilet brush in my hand, and I felt my whole body come down off its toes.

Tūtū called at eleven. She sounded tired.

"They're letting people back. Keola wants his ball. We're walking home."

"Mom, is that smart? Just stay at Rose's."

"Rose has one ceiling fan and it doesn't work, and she talks. I'm going home. The fire's out. The firemen are up there, they're watching it. I talked to one of them, nice boy, he's Leilani's [lay-LAH-nee] nephew. He said the fire's dead."

"Okay."

"You know what he said? He said they were lucky. He said if the wind had turned they'd have been in trouble, because half the trucks on the island are upcountry, up on the big mountain, at the other fire." She laughed a little. "Not enough fire trucks. Plenty of sprinklers in Kā'anapali, though."

"Mom."

"I'm just saying what the boy said." A pause. Wind. "Your son is pulling my arm. He wants to talk to you."

Keola came on. He was out of breath. "Mom! There was a *fire!* By the *school!* I saw the fire truck! It was *so big!*"

"I know, baby. I'm glad you're safe."

"The wind blew Auntie Rose's chair into the harbor! The whole chair!"

"Wow."

"Can I go swim later?"

"No. Not today. It's too windy. The water's rough. Stay with Tūtū."

"Aw."

"Keola."

"Okay," he said. "Bye. Love you." Exactly like his grandmother, three words and gone.

I stood in that guest's bathroom for a minute after he hung up, looking at the phone. Then I went back to work. I did all nine rooms. I folded the end of every toilet paper roll into a point.

I tell you this so you know how ordinary it was. A fire up the road, and then it was out. That's how the morning went. That's how it ends, usually. Out here, a grass fire in a high wind is nothing new. It burns, the trucks come, it gets put out, and you go home and you sweep the ash off the lanai and you say *that was close* and you have a beer.

That's what we thought. That's what everybody thought. The trucks thought it. The county thought it. The wind did not think it, but nobody asked the wind.

8. No Boat Today

Wes

The charter company texted at seven: *Due to high winds all tours cancelled today. Full refund or reschedule. Mahalo for understanding!*

I read it twice. I didn't know what *mahalo* [mah-HAH-loh] meant. I found out later it means thank you. I didn't feel thankful. I felt, I'm ashamed to say, relieved, and then I felt bad about the relief, because it meant another day of carrying her. I looked at the bag on the dresser and thought: one more day, Claire. Sorry. The wind.

The power was still out. No coffee. The refrigerator, when I opened it, breathed out warm. The milk I'd bought on Sunday smelled fine but felt wrong, like milk that had been somewhere without me. I gave Theo a granola bar and a banana and a juice box, and we ate them on the lanai, sitting on the floor with our backs to the wall because the wind was too strong to stand up in comfortably. It came off the mountain behind us, over the roof of our building, and went straight out to sea, and it was hot, which surprised me. You think of wind as cooling. This wind was warm and dry, like the air from a hair dryer, and it took the moisture out of your eyes and the inside of your nose until everything stung.

Out over the channel the sea was white to the horizon. The wind was tearing the tops off the waves and carrying the spray away in long smoking streaks, so it looked as if the whole surface of the ocean were on fire with white flames, all streaming in one direction, away from the island. Lāna'i was gone behind a haze. The sky above it was blue and perfectly clear and somehow wrong.

"It's really windy," Theo said.

"Sure is."

"Is the boat going?"

"Not today. Tomorrow maybe."

He nodded. I watched him. He looked out at the white water for a while and then he said, very carefully, "Okay," and I knew that he was relieved too. Neither of us said it.

...

Around eight we saw the smoke.

It was behind us, up the hill, over the rooftops on the other side of Front Street. A brown column going up and then, very quickly, bending flat, the wind catching it and stretching it out over the town toward the sea, so it passed right over us, high up, a long

brown smear across the blue. I could smell it. Grass smoke. Like a field burning in October back home.

People came out onto the street. A woman from the apartment downstairs, in a T-shirt that said *Lahaina Is My Happy Place*, stood on the sidewalk with her hand over her eyes. A man in a fishing hat said it was up by the high school. He said there were trucks there. He said, "Happens all the time, brah, with this wind," and I didn't know if *brah* [BRAH], which I learned later just means *brother*, was for me or for the woman, but it was friendly and it calmed me down.

By ten it was gone. The smoke thinned and stopped. The man in the fishing hat came back down the street and said, "They got it," and gave a thumbs-up, and the woman in the Happy Place shirt clapped, and everybody went back inside to not have air conditioning.

That was the morning fire. I've read everything about it since. I have read reports and timelines and the testimony of people who were there, and I've read it the way a man reads the last page of a book first, knowing how it ends, looking for the moment it could have gone the other way. I'll tell you plainly what I learned, since nobody told me then.

The fire started at about six-thirty-five in the morning, in tall dry grass at the side of Lahainaluna Road, the road that goes straight up the hill from town to the old school. Earlier, the wind had snapped the power lines there, and then the power came back on into the broken wires. A power line carries enough electricity to light a town. When a live broken end touches the grass, even for a second, it throws sparks and melted metal like a welder's torch. The grass caught. The wind pushed it. The firefighters came quickly and fought it, and they held it, and around the middle of the morning they announced it was contained, and then that it was out.

But a fire in grass isn't like a fire in a fireplace. It's not just flames you can see. It gets down into the roots and the dead stalks matted near the ground, into the dirt itself, and it can sit there smoldering, hidden, hot, without any flame at all, for hours. Firefighters have a name for this. They call it a holdover. And they have a job for it too: after the flames are gone, they walk the burned ground with hand tools, turning the dirt, feeling with the backs of their bare hands for

heat, soaking every hot spot until the ground is cold. It's called mop-up. It's slow and filthy and boring, and it is the most important part of the job.

That morning, the Maui Fire Department was stretched across the whole island. In the middle of the night another fire had started upcountry, in a place called Kula [KOO-lah], on the slopes of the big mountain on the other side of Maui, and it was burning toward houses there, and engines had gone. Firefighters were moving between fires. The wind was knocking down poles and lines all over the island, and every downed line was a new chance of fire.

A little after two in the afternoon, the crew watching the Lahaina burn left the scene. It was the right call by everything they could see. The fire was out. That was the information. The information was wrong.

. . .

We went out at noon, because the apartment was an oven. Front Street was strange. Most of the shops were closed with handwritten signs on the doors, *NO POWER*, *SORRY*, *CLOSED*, and a few were open with their doors propped wide, dim inside, selling whatever didn't need electricity. A woman at a fruit stand sold us two mangoes and a bag of something she called *li hing* [LEE hing] dried plums, which were sweet and sour and salty all at once and made Theo pull a face and then ask for more. She took cash only, no card machines. Everybody was talking about the wind. Everybody had a story: a tree down on their road, a roof gone, a boat dragging its anchor in the harbor.

We walked up to the banyan. I wanted to show Theo the tree in the wind. I'm not sure why. Maybe because Claire would have.

It was something. The great tree was alive with it. The thousands of branches were heaving, the leaves showing their pale undersides all at once in waves, silver-green, silver-green, so the whole crown of the tree seemed to ripple like water. And the sound. Under the banyan, in that wind, it sounded like being inside the ocean, a vast steady roar of leaves with the cracking of small branches in it, and the mynah birds screaming. The hanging roots were swinging like ropes in a gym. Twigs and leaves were raining down. The old men

with the cards were gone. Nobody was under there but us and a few tourists taking videos on their phones.

Theo stood in the middle of it with his arms out and his eyes shut, letting the wind push him. He was smiling. It was the first time I'd seen him smile with his whole face since we landed.

"It feels like flying!" he shouted.

"Yeah!"

"Do you think Mom sat here?"

"Right about here!"

He opened his eyes and looked at me. "Can we do the boat tomorrow?"

"If the wind stops."

"Okay." He shut his eyes again and leaned into the wind. "I think I want to go," he shouted. "On the boat. I want to see the deep part. For Mom."

I didn't say anything. I couldn't. I just stood next to him in the roaring green dark under that tree and nodded, which he couldn't see because his eyes were shut, and I put my hand on the back of his neck, which was hot and damp, and I left it there.

That was about two o'clock.

9. Go Work

Kanoe

At two I took my break on the bucket behind the laundry with a can of warm guava juice and checked my phone. One bar. No messages. I called home. It rang, and rang, and then a woman's recorded voice said the call couldn't be completed. I tried again. Same thing.

I wasn't worried yet. The cell towers had been going in and out all day. Half my texts were coming through an hour late, out of order, like mail delivered by a drunk.

I texted: *Mom you ok?*

The little circle turned and turned. Then: *Not delivered.*

. . .

I'm going to tell you something I saw that afternoon, which I didn't think about at the time but which I've thought about every day since.

From the laundry dock at the back of the resort you can see down the coast, south, toward Lahaina. Four miles. On a clear day you can see the harbor and the white steeple of the church and the dark green bump that is the banyan tree. That afternoon the wind had blown the air so clean that I could see all of it, sharp, like a photograph. And above the town, up the slope, there was the brown burned patch from the morning fire, a dark scar on the gold grass by Lahainaluna Road.

I looked at it. I remember thinking that it was smaller than I thought it would be. I remember being glad.

And I remember that there was a little gray haze hanging over it. Not smoke. Not really. More like the air over a road on a hot day, wavering.

I looked at that and I went back inside and did my last two rooms.

I have tried, since, to remember if I knew. If some part of me looked at that wavering air and knew what it was. I don't think so. I think I just saw a hot day. That's what everybody saw. The haze above a burned field in the wind, a little shimmer. That's all a holdover looks like, from four miles away. It looks like nothing.

. . .

At twenty past three, my supervisor came down to the laundry. His name doesn't matter. He was a nice man. His face was a color I'd never seen it.

"Kanoë," he said. "You're from Lahaina, yeah? Lahainaluna side?"

"Yeah."

"You should go look."

He didn't say anything else. He didn't have to. I walked out past him onto the loading dock and I looked down the coast, and the photograph had changed.

There was smoke over Lahaina. Not a column, like the morning. A wall. It was coming up from the town, from the slope above the town, from right where the morning's burned patch had been, black and brown and moving fast, and the wind was taking it, bending the top of it out over the sea in a long dark arm that stretched across the channel toward Lāna'i, getting wider and wider until it was a curtain, a black curtain pulled across the bottom of the sky. Under it, at the bottom, at the root of the smoke, I could see the color. You know the color. I don't have to tell you.

I took out my phone. One bar. I called home.

It rang.

It rang.

A recorded voice.

I called Auntie Rose. Recorded voice.

I called my cousin. It rang once and went dead.

I texted: *MOM FIRE GET OUT GO TO THE HARBOR GO NOW*

The little circle turned and turned.

Not delivered.

. . .

I don't remember deciding to go. I remember my keys in my hand, and the parking structure, and my car, and pulling out onto the highway headed south, and the sky in front of me so dark that every car on the road had its headlights on, at half past three in the afternoon, little yellow lights pushing into the dark.

The wind was hitting the car from the side so hard I had to hold the wheel with both hands. Dust and leaves and pieces of things were flying across the road. A sheet of roofing tin went over the car, flipping, flashing, like a giant playing card. Ahead of me, cars were stopped. Not slowing. Stopped. Brake lights all the way down the highway into the smoke, and people standing outside their cars, and a police car with its lights going sideways across both lanes.

The road into Lahaina was closed.

I got out and ran up to the policeman. He was young. He had a mask over his mouth and his eyes were red and streaming. I don't remember what I said. I remember he put his hand up flat, palm out, the way you'd stop a dog.

"Ma'am, nobody's going in. Road's closed. It's not safe."

"My son is in there. My mother. Lahainaluna. Off Lahainaluna."

"Ma'am."

"My son is *eight*."

He looked at me then. Just for a second, over the mask. He was crying, I realized. It wasn't the smoke. Or it was the smoke and also it wasn't.

"Ma'am," he said, "I've got a kid too. I'm sorry. I'm sorry. Nobody's going in."

I stood at that roadblock for an hour. I don't know what I did for an hour. I know that sometime around four the wind came down the highway carrying a sound I'd never heard before and never want to again: from inside the smoke, from somewhere in the town, a long rolling series of bangs, *pop, pop, pop-pop-pop*, like fireworks on New Year's, like a war in a movie.

That was cars. I found out later. That was the gas tanks of cars blowing up, one after another, all down Front Street.

10. The Hill Is Smoking

Wes

Just after three, walking back down Front Street toward the apartment, Theo stopped and pointed up over the rooftops behind the town.

"Dad. The fire's back."

I looked. Over the buildings, up the hill, where the morning smoke had been, there was smoke again. Gray at first, and thin, just a few wisps leaning out flat in the wind like a flag. Then, while I watched, it thickened. It turned brown. It turned black at the bottom. It came up in a fat rolling column that the wind caught at once and laid down sideways over the top of the town, right over our heads, so

the sun went orange and then went out, and the light on Front Street changed in a single second from white to the color of weak tea.

Somebody on the sidewalk said, "Oh, *no*."

There's a moment, when something terrible begins, when your body knows and your mind doesn't, and you stand there in between, like a man who's stepped off a curb he didn't know was there. I stood there. I held Theo's hand and looked up at the smoke going over and I thought: it's the morning fire again. They'll get it. That's what they do. The man in the fishing hat will come down the street and give a thumbs-up.

And something else in me, something below the thinking part, something that had stood on the edges of pools for twenty years watching for the one kid in a hundred who was in trouble before that kid knew it, said: *Get out of the water. Get out of the water right now.*

. . .

I'm going to slow down here. I'm going to tell you the next part carefully, the way I've told it to myself every night since, because if I go fast I'll lose it.

We went back to the apartment. That's what you do. You go home. I don't know why. You go home to get your things, your wallet, your phone charger, your ID, your kid's inhaler, your wife. I unlocked the door with my hands shaking. Inside it was dim and hot. Through the sliding door the sea was a strange dark green under the smoke, and the white streaks on it had turned orange, every one of them, reflecting the sky.

I put Theo on the couch. "Stay right there. Shoes on. Don't move."

I went to the bedroom and grabbed the backpack. I put in my wallet. Phone. The inhaler. The rental car keys, though the car was parked in a lot six blocks north and I didn't know if I'd be able to get to it. Two bottles of water. And then I stood at the dresser, with the bag of my wife sitting there in front of me, and I picked her up, all five pounds of her, and I put her in the backpack on top of everything else, and I zipped it, and I put it on.

I'm a practical man. I knew exactly what I was doing. I knew that if I had to choose between carrying my son and carrying my wife, I would put her down. I knew that. I took her anyway, because I wasn't going to leave her in a stranger's apartment in a burning town. I'd promised her somewhere warm. Not like this. Not this kind of warm.

When I came out Theo was standing at the sliding door with his hands flat on the glass, looking out at the water.

"Theo. Come on. We're going."

"Where?"

"To the car."

"Is the fire coming here?"

"I don't know, bud. We're going anyway. Come on."

He came. I took his hand. It was wet and cold, even in that heat. We went down the stairs and out onto Front Street, and the street had changed again while we were inside, like a stage when the lights change between scenes.

It was dark now. Not night dark. A brown dark, smoke dark, with a red light under it coming from somewhere up the hill behind the buildings, so that everything, the cars, the sidewalk, the people, the palm trees, had a red edge on one side, the way things look by firelight in a cave. The air tasted of burning, bitter on the back of the tongue. Ash was falling. Not big pieces yet. A fine gray snow, drifting sideways, settling on Theo's curls and on my arms.

And there were people everywhere. Everybody had come out at once. People in cars, in a long line already, honking, not moving. People on foot with bags, with dogs, with babies, with a birdcage, with a TV. An old man pushing a woman in a wheelchair down the middle of the street, the wheelchair's little front wheels catching on every crack. Kids crying. A woman screaming a name over and over, *Mika! Mika!* [MEE-kah], into the smoke.

And the sound. Under all the voices, under the honking, the wind. And under the wind, from up the hill, something else, a deep rumbling roar, like a freight train that never arrived, that just kept coming.

What I didn't hear was a siren. Not a warning siren. I heard car alarms, and somewhere a police car, and dogs, and people. But I'd seen the warning sirens on the poles around town, big gray horns on top of tall posts, the kind they have all over Hawaii for tsunamis, for anything. I'd noticed them on the first day and thought, that's good, they've got a system. They did. There were a lot of them, all along the west side.

Not one of them went off. Not that day.

I didn't think about it then. I didn't think about anything. I just held my son's hand and turned north up Front Street toward the parking lot where the car was, into the brown dark, through the falling ash, with my wife on my back.

Said in the Stream Bed

Let me tell you how I lost my floor. I said I would.

Up behind this town, in the folds of the mountain, there are valleys where I used to run. One of them is called Kaua'ula. If you walked up into it before the sugar came, you would have heard me before you saw me: a sound like a crowd of people all talking at once, a rushing that filled the whole valley, cold and white over the stones. I came down out of the cloud, out of the moss and the fern, down through the rocks, past the little terraces where the families grew their taro, and at the bottom I spread out through the town of Lele in a hundred channels, filling the fishponds and the taro pools and the king's pond in the middle, until I found my way to the sea. Where you are now. Right here.

Then men came with picks and shovels and dynamite, and with the laborers they brought, Chinese, Japanese, Filipino, Portuguese, Hawaiian, and they climbed up into my valleys, and they cut tunnels into the rock above the places where I ran, and they built walls across my beds, and they turned me.

I want you to understand that I did not stop running. I can't stop running. It isn't in me. I only went where they told me. They sent me sideways along the mountain in ditches, in long dark tunnels where I ran blind for miles, in wooden flumes on stilts over the gulches. I went to the cane. Mile after mile of cane, tall and green

and endlessly thirsty, and I gave myself to it, a ton of me for every pound of sugar, and the sugar went into ships, and the ships went to San Francisco, and the money went somewhere I never followed.

And in the town, the stream beds went dry. The taro pools cracked into plates of mud, curling up at the edges like old paper. The springs under the king's pond weakened, and the pond went still and green and stinking, and then they filled it in with earth, and they put a ballpark on top of the king's island, and the boys of the town played baseball over his bones.

That is a true thing. You can go and see it. Just a field.

The sugar left this side of the island at the end of the last century. Sugar could be grown cheaper elsewhere. The mill shut down. The cane was not replanted. You would think, wouldn't you, that I would be let go then. That the walls would come down and the tunnels would be sealed and I would be allowed, after a hundred years, to go home the old way, down my own valley, through my own town.

Not all of me. Some of me, yes. People fought for it. The families who still wanted to grow taro the old way went to the water commission, and they went to the courts, again and again, year after year, and they argued that I belonged to everyone, that a river cannot be owned, that the law of this state says so in plain words. And sometimes they won, a little. A little more of me was let back into a stream bed. And sometimes they lost. But by then there were other thirsts. There was the new land being sold above the town, the house lots, the big lots sold as farms to people who don't farm. There were the resorts up the coast with their lawns and their pools and their golf courses green as money. Somebody always needs me more than the stream bed does. That's how it goes, in the end. Somebody always has a better reason.

Here's what I want you to see, if you can.

On the day this happened, a man who managed some of the water on this side of the mountain wrote to the people in charge of me. He asked for permission to send more of me, out of the streams, into his reservoirs, so the reservoirs would be full if the fire came back. He was told to wait. He was told he needed to talk first to the farmers down below, the ones who used me for their taro, to make

sure taking more would not hurt them. That was the law. It was a law that had been fought for, by those same taro farmers, for exactly the reason you might expect: because for a hundred years the big users had taken whatever they wanted without asking. His own water man, the one who knew the system, had gone to get his family out, and the others couldn't be reached. Hours went by while the gates stayed shut.

Afterward the official who had asked him to wait was moved out of his job, and the people above him said it didn't mean he'd done anything wrong. Afterward people asked whether a full reservoir would have saved anything. The man who'd asked for the water himself said nobody could know. His reservoirs weren't even connected to the town's fire hydrants. Others said that didn't matter, a helicopter can dip a bucket in a reservoir. Others said the hydrants failed because the pipes melted in the burning houses and the water ran out of the broken pipes onto the ground, and the pressure dropped everywhere at once, and no reservoir on Earth could have fixed that. All of those things may be true together. That's what you'll have to decide.

I'll tell you only what I know, which is what water knows. I was up there that day. In the tunnels. In the ditches. In the tanks and the pipes and the reservoirs, held behind gates, waiting for someone to sign a piece of paper. A few miles below me, the town that I used to run through, the town that used to be named for my shade, was on fire, and I could not get to it.

I'm not telling you this to make you angry. Anger is a fire too. I'm telling you because some day you might wonder why I'm salty. Why I taste of tears.

It isn't only your tears. Some of it's mine.

III. THE SEAWALL

11. Nobody Rang Anything

Kanoe

At five o'clock I was sitting on the curb of the highway north of town with my phone in both hands, refreshing a screen that would not refresh.

There were hundreds of us. Cars pulled off on both shoulders, doors open, people standing on the hoods to see. People walking up the highway out of the smoke, out of Lahaina, with nothing. Black faces, black arms, eyes red as meat. A man in board shorts and nothing else, barefoot, the soles of his feet bleeding. A woman carrying a baby wrapped in a beach towel with a cartoon fish on it. They came out of the smoke in ones and twos and handfuls, and every time someone came, all of us who were waiting stood up at once, the way birds on a wire all lift together, and looked at their faces, and sat back down.

I asked every one of them. "Lahainaluna? Did you come from Lahainaluna? Did you see an old lady, white hair, a pencil in it? A boy, eight, no front teeth?"

Nobody had. Nobody had seen anything. "It came so fast," they said. They all said that. "It came so fast. It was everywhere. It was in the trees. It was in the air."

A man I knew a little from church, a big man with a voice like a truck in low gear, sat down next to me on the curb and put his face in his hands and said into them, "No siren. Kanoe. Nobody rang anything."

"What?"

"The sirens." He took his hands down and pointed, a soot-black finger, at a gray pole by the highway with the gray horn on top of it. There's one every so often all along the coast. Tsunami sirens. They test them on the first working day of every month at eleven-forty-five in the morning, a long rising wail, so regular that people check their watches by it. "They never set them off. Not one. You know how I found out? My neighbor banged on my door. My *neighbor*. With a garden hose in his hand."

I looked at the siren on the pole. Silent. Gray. Doing nothing in the wind.

Later we found out why. The man in charge of emergencies for the county said he didn't sound them because the sirens are for tsunamis, and people here are trained, when the siren goes, to run uphill, *mauka*, away from the sea. And the fire was uphill. He said he was afraid people would run into the fire. That was his reason. Some people believe him. Some people don't. He quit his job nine days later and said it was for health reasons. You decide.

I'll tell you what I think, and then I'll stop, because it doesn't matter what I think. I think if that siren had gone off, my mother would have turned on the radio. She had a little transistor radio with batteries in the kitchen drawer, for hurricanes. She'd have turned it on and listened, because that's what she did when the siren went. And she'd have heard the word *fire*. And she'd have had a few more minutes.

That's all. A few minutes. That's what a siren is. It doesn't put anything out. It just tells you to start running a little sooner.

. . .

The phones didn't work. Most of the cell towers on the west side had lost power the night before, and the ones with backup batteries had burned or run down. The landlines were down. The internet was down. There was no electricity anywhere in Lahaina, so there was no TV, and the radio station that might have said something wasn't saying much, because nobody knew much, because nobody could reach anybody. The county was putting messages on its website and its social media. Nobody in Lahaina could see them. There was no alert that came to people's phones with that loud screaming tone, the one they use for missing children and flash floods. Nobody sent it. Even if they had, most phones in the town had nothing to receive it with.

So the way you learned your town was burning was the way people learned it a thousand years ago. You smelled it. You saw it. Your neighbor banged on your door. Somebody ran down the street yelling.

That's how they got out, the ones who got out. People. Not systems. People yelling at people.

. . .

When it got dark the sky over Lahaina turned the color of the inside of a mouth. The smoke above the town was lit from underneath, red and orange and a strange deep pink, and it pulsed, brightening and dimming, as if something under there were breathing. Every so often there'd be a bigger flare, a burst of light shooting up into the smoke, and then a few seconds later a sound would roll up the highway, a deep *whump* you felt in your stomach. People said that was propane tanks. Gas stations. Boats in the harbor. The harbor was burning, someone said. Every boat in it.

My son jumps off the harbor wall. Every day. I told you.

A fire truck came up the highway out of the smoke, slow, with people standing on the back of it, holding on, and its lights going, and everybody ran toward it, and I ran too. People were climbing down off it, black from head to foot, coughing, some of them wrapped in wet blankets. A firefighter jumped down with his face all white around his mask, like a raccoon in reverse, and started shouting at us to stay back, give them room, there's a shelter at the civic center, go to the civic center, there's water there.

I grabbed his arm. "Lahainaluna. Did you go up Lahainaluna?"

He looked at me. "Ma'am, there's no Lahainaluna."

I didn't understand. "The road. Lahainaluna *Road*."

"Ma'am," he said again, gently, the way you'd talk to someone in a hospital, "it's all gone up there. That's where it started. It's all gone."

He pulled his arm away. Not hard. He had other people to tell.

I stood in the road with the fire truck's lights going round and round, red, white, red, across my face, and I said out loud, to nobody, "They went to Auntie Rose's. They went by the harbor."

Then I remembered they hadn't. At eleven they'd walked home. Keola wanted his ball.

12. The Wall

Wes

I'm going to tell you this the way it was for me then. I owe that night that much. Afterward I learned a great many things, and where I've learned better since, I'll say so, but I won't fix what I thought. If I fixed it, it wouldn't be what happened. It would be a report. So: the way it was.

. . .

We got four blocks north on Front Street. It took twenty minutes.

The street was solid with cars. Bumper to bumper, both lanes, all of them pointed north, all of them honking, none of them moving. People on foot were going faster than the cars, weaving between them, and every few seconds someone would give up on their car and get out and leave it there with the engine running and the door open and just start walking. The air was getting hotter. Not warm. Hot, the way it's hot when you open an oven to check on something and lean too close. The ash coming down was bigger now, pieces of it the size of my thumbnail, some of them still glowing orange at the edges, drifting down through the brown dark like slow fireflies.

I had Theo by the hand. I'd tied my T-shirt over his mouth and nose, wet with one of the bottles of water. He was walking with his eyes shut half the time, letting me pull him. He wasn't crying. That frightened me more than crying.

At the corner where I needed to turn to get to the parking lot, the street was blocked. A power pole was down across it, snapped off at the base, lying at an angle across the road with its wires hanging off it in loops, and there were men in hard hats and vests standing there waving people back. Utility crew. One of them was shouting, "Lines are down! Can't go this way! Lines are down! Turn around!"

A man in a pickup leaned out of his window and screamed at him, "Where?! Turn around to *where?!'*"

The utility guy just pointed. Back. South. Toward where we'd come from.

I didn't know what to do. I'm a man who always knows what to do, and I stood on that corner with my son and I didn't know which way

was away. Behind us, south, the smoke was thick and red. Ahead of us, north, the street was blocked and the cars were stopped and there was fire now on the right too, on the mountain side, in the yards behind the buildings, I could see it through the gaps between them: palm trees going up like torches, one after another, the whole crown of a tree catching at once in a great roaring ball of orange and the dead fronds tearing off and flying away in the wind, burning, over our heads, over the street, toward the sea.

The wind was carrying the fire. That's what I understood, standing there. It wasn't coming down the hill the way a fire burns down a candle. It was being thrown. The wind was picking up burning pieces of everything, leaves, fronds, shingles, wood, and throwing them ahead, a block ahead, two blocks, onto roofs and into yards and into the open windows of cars, and wherever they landed a new fire started, and the new fires joined up. It was everywhere at once. There was no edge to it, no front line, no place where you could stand and say, *this side is safe*.

There was only one direction it wasn't coming from.

I looked left, west, across Front Street, past the stopped cars, at the seawall and the water.

. . .

The seawall in Lahaina runs along the ocean side of Front Street for a long way. It isn't high on the street side, waist height, a concrete wall with a flat top you can sit on, the kind of wall where in a normal week people sit and eat their ice cream and watch the sunset. On the ocean side it drops, six or eight feet, onto a slope of big black boulders, and then the water. It's not a beach. It's rocks and water. When we'd arrived on Thursday there'd been a couple sitting on that wall with their legs dangling, sharing a pineapple out of a plastic cup, and I'd thought: that's the life.

There were people on it now. Climbing it. Going over.

I pulled Theo across the street, between the cars. A car door opened in front of us and I nearly ran him into it. Someone was screaming inside one of the cars, a long high sound, and I didn't look. I'm sorry. I didn't look. We got to the wall. Below us the rocks, slick and black, and the waves coming in on them white, hard, the

wind blowing the spray off the tops, and floating in the water, holding onto the rocks, holding onto each other, people. Twenty. Thirty. In the dark, in the red light, their faces turned up toward the street, toward the fire.

Theo saw the water and pulled back so hard his hand came out of mine.

"No," he said. "No. No. Dad. No."

"Theo."

"No."

He was backing up, back toward the cars, toward the fire. I grabbed him. I got him by both arms. He fought me. He was nine and skinny and he fought me like an animal, kicking, twisting, his face screwed up, crying finally, crying and screaming, *no no no, I can't, I can't, Dad, I can't see under it*, and behind him a car's windshield cracked with the heat with a noise like a pistol shot, and I picked him up. I picked him up like a toddler, both arms round his body, his legs kicking against me, and I held him against my chest, and I said into his hair, "I've got you. I've got you. I've got you."

And that's when the old woman came.

. . .

She came out of the smoke from the north, from the side street, walking. Not running. She couldn't run. She was small and round, wearing a mu'umu'u [MOO-oo MOO-oo], a long loose flowered dress, and men's rubber slippers, and she was holding a boy by the hand. The boy was pulling her, trying to make her go faster, and she was coming as fast as she could, which wasn't fast. Her white hair had come loose and was blowing straight out sideways from her head in the wind like smoke itself. Her face was black with soot except for two clean lines down her cheeks where the tears had run.

The boy was the kid from the harbor wall. I knew him at once, even then, even black with ash. Skinny. All elbows. Hair sticking up at the back. He saw the water below the wall and he didn't pull back. He pulled *toward* it.

The old woman looked at the wall. She looked at me, holding Theo, and at the people in the water, and then she looked down at her own legs, at her swollen ankles in the men's slippers, and I saw her decide. I saw it. I've seen a thousand swimmers on a thousand starting blocks, and I know what a person's face does in the half-second when they decide to go, and her face did the opposite.

"You," she said to me. Her voice was hoarse from the smoke but it carried. It was a voice used to carrying. "You can swim?"

"Yes."

"Good." She pushed the boy forward, toward me, and the boy turned and looked up at her. "Take him."

"Tūtū—" the boy said.

"He swims," she said to me, over the boy's head, fast, hard, every word a separate stone. "He swims better than you. But he's eight. You hold him. You don't let go. You understand me? Whatever. You hold on."

"Ma'am, come on, you come too, I'll help you down—"

"I'm not going in there." She almost laughed. It came out a cough. "Seventy-nine years I never went past my knees. Too late to start." She looked at the boy. Her face did something I won't describe. "Go with Uncle," she said to him. "Go on. I'll be right here. I'll be right here on the wall."

"Tūtū—"

"Go." She put her hand on top of his head, flat, for just a second. Then she took it off and pushed his shoulder, toward me, toward the wall, toward the water, and she said the last thing. She said it to me. I've heard it every night since.

"Take my life," she said. "Go on. Take my life."

She didn't look at me when she said it. She was looking at him. I've thought since that she was making sure of something, the way you check a knot before you trust your weight to it: his face, the hair standing up at the back, the gap where his front teeth had been. She looked at him the way you look at a thing for the last time when you know it is the last time and have decided not to make a fuss

about it. Then she brought her hand back and folded it inside her other hand, in front of her, against the flowers of her dress, and held it there, as though it were still warm from the top of his head and she meant to keep the warmth for as long as it would last.

I didn't understand her. I thought she was out of her mind with the smoke. I thought she meant, *my life is over, save yourself*, or something like that, something old women say in movies. I didn't know, then, what the boy's name meant.

There wasn't time. The fire was in the building across the street now, the one with the T-shirt shop in it, the windows bursting out one after another, *pop, pop, pop*, and the heat came across the road like an open door.

I sat on the wall. I swung my legs over. Theo was locked round my neck now, his arms so tight I could hardly breathe, his face crushed into my shoulder, and he'd stopped fighting, he'd gone rigid, like a cat. I put my free hand down. The other boy took it. His hand was small and hot and very strong.

"Ready?" I said to him.

He nodded.

We went over. I slid down the rough face of the wall on my backside, Theo locked on my chest, the harbor boy sliding beside me with his hand in mine, and the rocks came up to meet us.

13. The Color of the Inside of a Mouth

Kanoe

The civic center is a big gym and a parking lot on the highway between Kā'anapali and Lahaina, outside the fire. By nine o'clock that night there were hundreds of people in it. They'd found generators. There were lights. There were cots coming in on trucks, and pallets of bottled water, and a church group from up the coast handing out rice and Spam musubi [moo-SOO-bee], which is a block of rice with a slice of fried Spam on top wrapped in seaweed, which is what you eat here when anything happens, birthday, funeral, end of the world.

I didn't eat. I walked.

There was a whiteboard by the door where people were writing names. Somebody had started it and everybody had joined in, so it was already full, both sides, names written over names, in marker and in pen and in lipstick: *LOOKING FOR* and then a name and a street and a phone number that didn't work. I found a space at the bottom corner and I wrote, small, because there was hardly room:

KEOLA, 8. TŪTŪ (79). LAHAINALUNA. — KANOE

I stood back and looked at it. It looked like nothing. It looked like a grocery list. I'd written my son's name with a marker that was running out, so the K was dark and the A at the end was pale gray, nearly gone.

I went outside and walked across the parking lot to where you could see the town.

. . .

People had gathered at the edge of the lot, on a little rise of dry grass, and they were all standing very still, looking south. I stood with them. Nobody talked. I don't think I've ever stood with so many people in so much silence.

Below us, Lahaina was burning.

I'm going to try to tell you what it looked like, because I promised myself that if I lived through it I'd tell it right, even the parts I don't want to.

The whole town was a lake of fire. From the slope behind it to the sea, from end to end, every street, every block, glowing, red and orange and white, so bright that the smoke above it was lit up like the underside of a cloud at sunset, and the light came all the way up to where we were standing and painted our faces orange. You could see shapes inside the fire. The black skeletons of houses, standing up in the glow like the ribs of animals. Trees, like burning candles, a whole row of them along the road. A shape that I knew was the old church, the steeple, standing up straight and black against the brightness, and then, while I watched, slowly, leaning, and then gone.

And the sea. That was the worst. The sea in front of the town was red. The fire was reflected in it, the whole wide water from the

seawall out to the reef glittering red and gold, moving, shining, so it looked as if the ocean were on fire too. And out in the harbor there were boats burning on the water, little ones and big ones, each one a separate fire floating on its own reflection, drifting slowly as their ropes burned through.

I stood there and thought: Keola jumps off that wall.

I stood there and thought: Mom doesn't swim. Mom has never in her life gone past her knees.

I stood there and thought: they're at Rose's. They went back to Rose's. Rose's is by the harbor. The harbor is on fire.

I stood there and thought: no. They walked home. Keola wanted his ball.

I stood there and thought, and thought, in circles, the same three thoughts, round and round, like a dog chasing a smell, and the fire went on and on in front of me, and nobody on that hill said one word.

. . .

Around midnight a woman next to me, an older woman with a towel round her shoulders, started to sing.

Very quietly. Just under her breath at first. An old song, a *mele* [MEH-leh], which is the word for a Hawaiian song or chant, a song for a place. It was a song about Lahaina. About the breadfruit shade, and the sun, and the rain that comes down off the mountain in the night. I knew it. Every kid here learns it in school. One by one, the people standing on that hill joined in, very softly, until there were maybe fifty of us singing in the dark, in the orange light, looking down at our town burning, singing it a song about how beautiful it was.

I sang too. I didn't decide to. I just did.

I'll tell you something I've never told anyone. While I was singing, I had a feeling, very clear, very strong, like a hand on my back, that my mother was singing too. Somewhere down there. Not dead, not alive, just singing. I could almost hear her, her voice under all the others, that voice that could reach the end of the lane without trying.

That was the smoke, probably. We were all breathing a lot of smoke. It does things to you.

I'm telling you anyway. I promised to tell it right.

14. The Long Night

Wes

The first thing the water did was hit us.

We went off the wall onto the rocks and the rocks were slick, black, covered in some kind of slime, and a wave came in as we landed and knocked my feet out from under me, and we went down together, all three of us, into the white churning water between the boulders. I went under. Theo went under with me, still locked round my neck. I felt his whole body jerk in panic. I got my feet on something and stood and came up and dragged him up with me, and he was choking, coughing salt water, screaming between coughs. And the other boy, the harbor boy, came up a few feet away, calm, his hair plastered flat, and swam to me in two strokes and grabbed the strap of my backpack, and held on.

Then the next wave came and we were all together against the rocks.

That's how it was for a long time. I'm going to try to tell you how it was.

. . .

The water was waist deep where I stood, sometimes chest deep, when the waves came in. I had my back against a big rock at the base of the seawall, with the wall going up above us, and the rock was rough and it scraped my back every time a wave pushed me into it. I had Theo in front of me, his arms round my neck, his legs round my waist. I had the harbor boy on my left side, holding my backpack strap, floating easy, his chin just above the water. Every time a wave came he rose with it like a cork and came down and was still there.

The waves were the hard part. The wind was blowing off the land, out to sea, so you'd think the waves would be small, but they weren't. They came in big and crooked, wild, as if the whole ocean

were confused, and they rolled in and broke over us and pushed us into the rocks, and then sucked out and tried to drag us off the rocks and out into the dark, and we'd hang on, and they'd come in again. Every wave, I braced. Every wave, I counted. A coach counts. One, two, here it comes, hold. *Hold*. Three, four, five, breathe. I counted waves the way I count laps, out loud sometimes, so the boys could hear me. A hundred waves. Two hundred. I lost count somewhere after three hundred and started again.

Above us was the fire.

Picture it from where I was. I was looking up from the bottom of a wall, from the water, at the sky. The sky was gone. There was no sky. There was a ceiling of smoke, low, rolling, black and brown and lit from below in red, and it was moving, fast, out over the water above us, going out to sea, and out of it, all the time, coming down, was fire. Embers. Sparks. Burning things. Pieces of palm frond, still flaming, came spinning down out of the dark and hit the water around us and hissed and went out. Pieces of paper. Pieces of roof. Something that I think was part of a beach umbrella came down burning like a parachute and landed on the rocks ten feet from us and burned there for a long time.

The heat came over the wall in waves, like the water came. You could feel it on the top of your head, on your face if you looked up. We kept our heads down. Every so often, when a really bad gust came, a gust full of embers, I'd say, "Under!" and we'd all three duck our heads under the water for as long as we could, and I'd feel the hot rain of sparks on the back of my neck through the water, and we'd come up gasping.

Theo couldn't go under. Not by himself. The first time I said "Under!" he just clung to me and screamed, and a piece of burning something landed on his shoulder and I slapped it off. After that I did it for him. I'd say "Breathe, bud, hold it, hold it," and I'd wait till he took a breath, and I'd put my hand over his face and take him down with me. Two seconds. Three. Up. He'd come up choking and screaming and I'd say, "Good, good, that's good, you did it," the way I'd say it to a six-year-old at the Y.

The harbor boy went under by himself every time. He didn't need to be told. He'd see a gust coming before I did and duck, quick, neat, and come up, wipe his face with one hand, and hold on.

. . .

The smoke was the thing that got into me.

It came down on the water in long rolling banks, sometimes so thick I couldn't see the boys a foot from my face, couldn't see my own hand. It got in your throat and your chest and burned like breathing pepper. Down at the water it was a little better, the air right at the surface, so we kept our faces low. But it got in anyway. All night it got in. My head started to ache, a deep, slow, throbbing ache behind my eyes. My eyes stopped working right. Everything got blurry and doubled and stung so bad I could hardly keep them open. And my thinking slowed. It went thick and strange, like thinking underwater.

I know now what that was. The smoke from a fire is full of a gas called carbon monoxide, which you can't see or smell, and which gets into your blood and takes the place of oxygen. A little of it gives you a headache. More makes you confused, slow, dreamy, sleepy. More than that makes you see things. More than that, and you lie down and don't get up. People who breathe smoke for hours in a fire, I've since read, often remember the night afterward in pieces, out of order, full of things that couldn't have been there.

So some of what I'm about to say couldn't have been there.

I'll say it anyway.

. . .

At some point, I don't know when, I don't know what hour, the water started to get cold.

You'd think it couldn't. It's Hawaii. The water's warm as a bath. But if you stand in a bath for three hours, four hours, with the wind blowing over your wet head and shoulders, it takes the heat out of you a little at a time, and doesn't give it back. I started to shake. My teeth went. I could feel Theo shaking against me, his whole little body rattling like a machine.

And the explosions. Cars, along Front Street, right above us. A car's gas tank goes up with a flat, thudding bang that you feel in your chest more than hear, and then a whoosh, and a wave of heat, and burning pieces of car come over the wall. They went off every few minutes, all down the street, some close, some far. Every time one went off close, the boys flinched against me.

. . .

Here is the part I have to tell carefully.

Sometime after it was fully dark, a car went up just along from us. On the street above the wall, maybe twenty feet down. I don't know what was in it. The bang wasn't a bang. It was a blow, like being hit in the face with a door. A sheet of white fire came out over the top of the wall, and a wave came in at the same time, a big one, the biggest yet, and I don't know which hit us first. I know that I went under. I know that I was thrown off the rock, pushed along the bottom, rolled over, my shoulder slammed into something hard, my head hit something, and I couldn't tell which way was up. Everything was black and roaring and full of bubbles. My arms were empty.

My arms were empty.

I have held children in water for twenty years. A child in water weighs almost nothing. Five pounds, maybe, of a sixty-pound boy; the sea takes the rest. You stop feeling it after a while. It becomes part of your arms, the way a watch becomes part of your wrist, and you only know it's there when it's gone. That's how I knew. Not by looking. I couldn't see anything. By the lightness. My arms came up through the black water too fast, too easy, as if a rope had been cut, and that lightness was the worst thing I have ever felt in my life, worse than the heat, worse than the smoke. Five pounds. About what his mother weighed in the bag. My arms knew before I did.

I came up. I don't know how. I was a few yards out from where we'd been, in deeper water, and I couldn't touch bottom, and I couldn't see. Smoke on the water, thick, and the red light through it, and the waves, and I was turning, turning in the water, screaming his name.

"THEO! *THEO!*"

Nothing. Waves. Smoke.

"THEO!"

And then something bumped against my chest in the dark, small, kicking, coughing. A boy. I grabbed him. I got my arms round him and pulled him into me and he came, he grabbed my neck, he held on, coughing, retching up seawater against my shoulder, his heart going like a hummingbird against mine.

"I've got you," I said. "I've got you. I've got you, bud. I've got you."

I swam us back to the wall. I don't know how I found it. I found it. I got my back against a rock again and my feet on the bottom.

Then I remembered the other one.

"The other boy," I said, out loud, to the dark. "The other boy." I had his grandmother's voice in my ear: *You hold him. You don't let go. Whatever.*

I yelled. I didn't know his name. Did I? Had she said it? I couldn't remember. The smoke. I yelled "HEY! KID! HEY!" into the dark and the smoke and the red light, over and over, and I waited, and there was nothing but the waves and the fire and, far down the wall, other people in the water, yelling other names.

And this is what I thought, exactly, because it's the thing I'll answer for, whatever there is to answer to.

I thought: he swims. She said it. *He swims better than you.* I saw him backflip off the harbor wall. I saw him swim like a seal. He's fine. He's somewhere down the wall with the others, holding on. He can swim. He'll be fine. He's the one who'll be fine.

I held my son against my chest and I told myself that, and I believed it, because I needed to, and because I had my son.

. . .

The hours after that I can only give you in pieces.

The boy in my arms stopped shaking. That's the first piece. I don't know how long after. Maybe an hour. He'd been rigid, his arms locked round my neck, and then at some point I felt him go soft. I was terrified, I thought he'd passed out, and I pulled his head back

to look at him. And he was awake. His eyes were open, looking at me, black face, white eyes. And he let go of my neck. He let go, and lay back, and put his ears in the water, and floated. Just like I'd taught him a hundred times when he was four. Arms out. Chin up. Ears under. Giving the water his weight. He lay there in the black and red water, held only by my hand flat under the small of his back, floating, calm, breathing slow, looking up at the burning sky.

I started to cry. I'm not ashamed of it. I stood there against that rock with my hand under my son's back and cried like a child, because he was floating. Because after two years he'd finally done it, he'd finally trusted the water. Here. Tonight. In the middle of hell. Claire, I said. Claire, look. He's floating. He's doing it.

I kept my hand where it was, flat under his back. With a kid who has just learned, you leave it there longer than you need to, so they never feel the moment it goes. Above us the smoke went over, red and black, and pieces of the town came down burning and hissed out on the water a few feet off, and he watched them fall the way you'd watch snow from a window. His breath went in and out, slow. I could feel it through my palm, the small rise of his ribs, the water lifting him a little higher on every breath in and letting him down on every breath out. Fifteen breaths a minute. Fourteen. Twelve. I counted them. I would have counted them all night.

. . .

That's the second piece. Here's the third.

At some point, the boy in my arms called me *Uncle*.

He said, quiet, in a voice that sounded like it came from far off, "Uncle, my Tūtū stay on the wall?" There was a little whistle in it, at the edges of the words. I thought it was his teeth chattering.

And I laughed. God help me, I laughed. I thought he was remembering the kid from the harbor, the one who'd called me Uncle, the one who'd come into the water with us. I thought the smoke had him mixed up, the way it had me mixed up. I said, "We'll find her, bud. Don't worry. We'll find everybody."

And later, another time, he said a word I didn't know. He was floating with his face to the sky and he said, very soft, almost

singing, "*Kai* [KYE]." Just that. A word I didn't know. "*Kai*." I thought it was a name. I thought maybe he was saying *Claire*, the way he used to say it when he was two and couldn't get his mouth round it, *Kai, Kai*. I said, "She's here, bud. She's right here." And I believed that too.

...

The fourth piece is the one I can't explain.

Sometime in the deepest part of the night, the smoke lifted off the water for a while, and I looked up, and Lahaina wasn't burning anymore.

It was gone. The fire was gone. The burning buildings were gone, and the cars, and Front Street. And in their place, under the red sky, there was a different town. There were trees. Enormous, dark, round-headed trees, hundreds of them, breadfruit, I know now, though I didn't know the word then, standing in groves with paths between them. And there was water everywhere. Running water. I could hear it. Streams coming down out of the dark from the mountain, dozens of them, pouring through the town in channels lined with stone, glittering red in the firelight. And pools, square pools stepping down the slope one after another, flooded and shining like mirrors, with green leaves standing up out of them, big leaves shaped like hearts. And right there, close, just over where the wall had been, there was a wide pond, still and black, and in the middle of the pond a small island, with a low house on it made of grass, and torches burning in front of the house, and somebody standing in the doorway.

I could hear the water running. That's what I remember most. The whole town full of the sound of running water, like the town itself was laughing.

And I could hear, on the wall above me, very clear, an old woman singing.

I don't know the words. It wasn't English. It was slow, and it went up and down like the waves, and it didn't stop. It just went on and on, a voice used to carrying, singing into the fire. Singing to somebody.

I lay back against the rock with my son floating under my hand, and I listened to that woman singing, and I listened to the water running through the old town, and for a while, I don't know how long, I wasn't afraid of anything.

Then the smoke came back down, and the town was burning again, and the singing had stopped.

. . .

The last piece is this.

My backpack had torn. I didn't know when. Somewhere in the rocks, in the blast, in the wave. The strap that the harbor boy had been holding had ripped half away from the bag, and the bag had a long gash down the side, and everything in it was gone, the wallet, the phone, the water bottles, the inhaler. All of it gone into the dark.

I noticed it near the end. I put my hand back to feel for the inhaler, because the boy's breathing had gone rough, and the bag was empty, just a torn wet sack hanging off my shoulder.

And around us in the water, from the bang onward, there had been a strange pale cloudiness. I didn't understand it. I thought it was ash from the fire. A soft gray haze in the water, just under the surface, drifting, catching the red light. It came and went with the waves. It was there on my arms and on the boy's chest when I looked. A fine pale dust, like flour. Like the finest sand.

I put my hand in it and watched it slide off my fingers and I thought: ash. The town. That's the town.

It wasn't only the town.

15. Dawn

Kanoe

The sun came up on the ninth of August the way it does every morning in Lahaina: from behind the mountain, slow, the sky over the ridge going gray, then pale gold, then a thin bright line along the top of the mountain like the edge of a knife.

Except the mountain was black.

I'd fallen asleep on the grass at the edge of the parking lot, sitting up, with my knees pulled to my chin, and I woke up with the sun coming over the ridge and the first thing I saw was that the mountain behind Lahaina, the slope I had looked at every day of my life, was black from the town halfway to the clouds. Black and smoking. Gray smoke drifting up off it in a thousand thin threads, like steam off a cup.

And below it, where the town had been, there was smoke too. Not fire anymore, mostly. A gray low haze, flat, lying over everything, so you couldn't see what was under it. Here and there, through the haze, a little orange glow still, a few spots still burning. A thin column going up from where the harbor was. The banyan, I thought. I looked for the dark green bump of the banyan tree. I couldn't find it. I couldn't find anything. There was nothing to find it against.

People were waking up around me on the grass. Nobody said anything. We stood up, one at a time, and looked.

. . .

All that morning they came out. Buses, trucks, ambulances, cars, people walking. All morning I stood at the entrance to the civic center and watched every face.

I want to tell you about the faces. Most of them were not hurt, not in a way you could see. They were just black, from the smoke, every one of them, hair and skin and clothes, all the same color, as if the fire had made them all one family. Their eyes were red. Some of them had burns, on their arms, on their backs, red and wet, and they went straight to the medical tent, where a nurse from the hospital in Wailuku, who hadn't slept since the day before, was cleaning burns. A lot of them were wet. Soaked. Seawater dried white on their clothes in salt lines. People said that a lot of them had been in the ocean. All night. Along the seawall. That the firefighters had got some of them out after midnight and the rest after it got light. That surfers had paddled in through the reef on their boards in the dark and taken the little kids first.

I asked every one. "Did you see an old lady, white hair? Was there a boy? Eight. No front teeth. A swimmer."

One woman, very young, with a baby, looked at me a long time. "There was a lot of boys," she said. "In the water. I don't know. I'm sorry. I'm sorry."

Everyone was sorry. I was sorry. I was sorry for everything. I was sorry I went to work. I was sorry I didn't wake him. I was sorry about the dishes and the loose nail in the roof and every time I'd shouted at him to get off the harbor wall. I was sorry I hadn't charged my phone a third time.

. . .

At about nine I went back inside the gym to look at the whiteboard. Somebody had written underneath my message, in blue: *TŪTŪ AND KEOLA — SAW THEM LAHAINALUNA 3PM WALKING MAKAI. — D. Makai. Toward the sea.*

I stood and read it ten times. Walking toward the sea. At three. That was all. Somebody named D. had seen them walking down the hill toward the sea, toward Front Street, at three o'clock in the afternoon. I didn't know any D. I didn't care. I wanted to find D. and hold their face in my hands and kiss them.

Toward the sea. Not toward the fire. Toward the sea.

Tūtū, you smart old woman. You smart, smart old woman.

I was still standing there, with my fingers on the blue letters as if I could read more out of them by touch, when I heard someone calling my name across the gym. A man's voice. Loud. Calling it over and over, the way you call someone in a crowd when you've got something you can't hold much longer.

"Kanoë! *Kanoë!* Anybody seen Kanoë from Lahainaluna?! *Kanoë!*"

16. I Got Him

Wes

The boards came out of the dark sometime after midnight.

I didn't see them at first. I heard them. Voices, out on the water, behind us, beyond the reef, men shouting to each other in a mix of English and something else, and then a splashing, steady, rhythmic, the sound of arms paddling hard. And then, out of the smoke, low

on the water, there they were. Three men on surfboards, lying flat on their stomachs, paddling in through the gap in the reef toward the wall, toward us, toward all the people in the water. They had headlamps on, little white lights bobbing in the smoke.

People along the wall started shouting. "Here! Here! Over here! Kids! There's kids!"

The first board came straight for us. A big man, older, heavy in the shoulders, lying on a long board, his headlamp swinging. He came in close, slid off the board into the water beside me, held the board steady with one hand. His face was black like everybody's. His eyes were white.

"Keiki [KAY-kee] first," he said. *Keiki*, I know now, means *children*. "Brah. Give me the boy. I take him out to the boat. Got one boat outside the reef. Give him."

I didn't want to let go. I had held him all night. I had promised. *You don't let go. Whatever.*

"Careful with him," I said. "That's Theo. That's my Theo. You're okay, bud. You're okay."

"It's okay," the man said. "Brah. It's okay. I got him."

I lifted the boy off my chest. He was floating, still, half asleep. I lifted him up and the man took him under the arms and slid him onto the front of the surfboard, on his stomach, and put one big hand flat on his back to hold him there.

The man looked at the boy's face in the light of the headlamp. And something happened in the man's face. I saw it even through the black and the smoke. It went still, and then it broke open.

"Eh," he said, very soft. "*Eh.*" Then louder, to the other boards, to the dark, his voice cracking: "I got him! I got him! *I got him!*"

I thought he meant: I've got him. Safe. Like you'd say it to a parent. I thought that's what everybody said.

"Thank you," I said. "Thank you. Thank you." I couldn't stop saying it.

The boy turned his head on the board and looked back at me. Black face. White eyes. In the headlamp light. He looked at me for a long

moment, the way a child looks at a stranger, and he lifted one hand off the board, a little, and he said:

"Bye, Uncle."

Then the man was paddling, kicking, pushing the board out through the waves toward the gap in the reef and the boat beyond it, and the headlamp went bobbing away into the smoke, smaller, smaller, and was gone.

Bye, Uncle. I stood there in the water against the rock and I smiled, I swear to you, I smiled, because I thought: he's still doing it. He's still mixed up, still playing the harbor kid. That's my funny boy. That's my brave, funny boy.

. . .

The firefighters came down the wall at about one-thirty in the morning. I learned the time later. Ladders, ropes, headlamps, big men in yellow coats, reaching down, pulling people up one by one. Two of them pulled me up. I couldn't climb. My legs wouldn't work. They'd been in the water nine hours and they'd forgotten what they were for. The firefighters lifted me over the top of the wall like a sack of something and laid me on the street.

Along the top of the wall, in the smoke, there were people sitting who didn't get up when the firefighters passed them. I saw them the way you see furniture in a dark room, a shape, and then another shape. Nobody went to them. I didn't look closer. I've had to live with that too, so I'll say it plainly: I didn't look.

The street was burning. Still. Not everywhere now, but in patches, the cars along the curb burned down to black frames, glowing red in their wheel wells, the buildings across the road just walls now, empty windows full of orange light. The heat on my face. The smell, which I won't describe, because somebody reading this has children, and I don't want you to have to know it.

They carried me to a fire truck and put me on the back of it with other people from the water. Somebody put a blanket on me. Somebody gave me a bottle of water and I couldn't hold it, my hands were shaking too much, so they held it for me while I drank.

"My son," I said. "My son. A man took him on a surfboard. To a boat."

"Okay," said the firefighter. "Okay. They took a bunch of kids out to the boats. They'll bring them in by boat up the coast and take them to the shelter. You'll find him. Okay? You'll find him."

"He's nine. Theo. Curly hair."

"Okay. You'll find him. Drink your water."

The truck started to move. Slowly, around burned cars, through smoke, along what had been Front Street, past what had been the banyan tree, which I couldn't see, which I couldn't see anything of. People on the back of the truck were crying, or quiet, or coughing. I was smiling. I know how that sounds. I was lying on the back of a fire truck going through the ruins of a town where I didn't know how many people had died and I had my face turned up to the smoke, and I was smiling, because my son had floated. Because he had done it. Because he was on a boat, outside the reef, safe, and in a few hours I'd find him in some shelter wrapped in a blanket and I'd pick him up and tell him, You floated, bud. You floated all night. Your mom saw.

I closed my eyes. I was so tired. I'd been counting for nine hours.

I stopped counting.

Said at the Seawall

I'll tell you what I saw when they came over the wall. I saw all of it. I'm the only one who did.

I saw them come over the wall. Forty of them, more or less, along that stretch of stone, and others in other places, at the harbor, on the beach to the north, in the shallows by the boat ramp. They came down onto my rocks out of the burning street, the way animals come down to a river when the forest is on fire. They didn't think about it. Something older than thinking told them: *the water*. Go to the water. Even the ones who were afraid of me came. Even the ones who'd never gone past their knees.

I held them.

I want you to know I tried. I'm not a gentle thing. I've thrown boats onto the rocks and taken whole beaches away in a night. But I tried. I made myself warm for them, as warm as I could for as long as I could. I lifted them when the waves came, so they wouldn't be dragged along the bottom. I put my body between them and the sky when the burning things came down. I hid their faces in me, in my dark, again and again, and the embers hissed against my skin and went out, and the ones I was hiding came up again breathing.

There was a woman who held on to a boat's anchor rope all night so the waves wouldn't take her. There was a family of five on a piece of plywood. There was a toddler holding on to the neck of a stranger. There was a boy, nineteen, who told his mother and his little brother that if it came to it he would swim them to the next town at first light, and meant it. There was an old man who couldn't bear it anymore and climbed back up over the wall into the street. There were people calling for each other in the dark, all night, names going up into the smoke and nobody answering. I heard all of them. I kept all the names.

Here is what I couldn't do.

I couldn't go up the wall. That's all. Twenty feet. The width of a street. The fire was right there, right above me, burning the town that had once been named for my shade, burning the houses built on the beds where I used to run, and I lay at the bottom of the wall all night with my arms full of people and I could not climb twenty feet to put it out.

Do you understand? I'm not asking you to forgive anyone. I don't know who to forgive, and neither do you. I'm only asking you to understand how it looked from down here. On the land above me, hydrants opened and nothing came out, or a little came out and then nothing, because the pipes were melting in the burning houses and I was pouring out of the broken ends onto the ground, wasted, running away under the floors. Up in the mountain I was sitting in tunnels and tanks behind closed gates. And down here, I was everywhere. I was a whole ocean, right there, a few steps away. And no one could carry me up.

In the harbor the boats burned on top of me. You could see the fire on them and the fire under them, their reflections, two flames for each boat, one reaching up and one reaching down, like hands trying to touch through glass. They burned to their waterlines, and then I took them. One by one. They came down to me slowly, hissing, and lay on my floor, and I hold them now, all of them, in the dark under the harbor, with the old anchors and the whalers' bottles and the bones of the first canoes.

Toward the middle of the night, the old woman on the wall began to sing.

She had sat down on top of the wall, right above the place where the man was holding the boys. She'd sat there since the start, with her slippers off and her bare feet hanging over the edge, over me. I don't think she could have gone anywhere else. Her legs were done. And sometime in the night, when the smoke was very bad and the heat was coming over the street in waves, she began to sing. Old words. A song for this place, a song her grandmother sang to her, about the shade of the breadfruit and the streams running down at night. She sang it out over me, slow, up and down. She sang it the whole way through, and then she started again from the beginning. And sometime after that, I don't know when, she stopped.

She wasn't singing to the fire. I want you to know that. She wasn't singing to God, or to her daughter, or to herself. She was singing down. Down over the edge of the wall, into the dark, into the water, where she couldn't see anymore, to someone she'd given away.

I carried every word of it. I carried it down into me, every note, and kept it. I have it now.

I'll give it to you later. When you need it.

IV. UNACCOUNTED

17. Another Name

Kanoe

It was Bully calling my name.

That isn't his real name. Nobody knows his real name, or nobody uses it. He lived three houses down from us on the lane, a big heavy man of sixty with a gray ponytail and hands like baseball gloves, and he'd taught half the kids on our street to surf, including me, a long time ago, and including my son. He had a dog called Poi [POY], after the soft purple paste we make from taro root, and a truck that didn't run. He used to sit on his lanai in the evenings with a beer and holler at Tūtū across and down the lane about the news, and she'd holler back, and that was their friendship, forty years of hollering.

He was standing in the middle of the gym, black from head to foot, in a pair of wet board shorts and nothing else, with his ponytail burned half off and a blanket round his shoulders, and in his arms he was holding my son.

I don't remember crossing the gym. I remember Keola's face. I remember that it turned toward my voice, and that his eyes found me, and that he didn't say anything. He didn't cry or shout or reach for me. He just looked at me, the way you look at something from very far away, from the other end of a long tunnel. Then Bully put him down and he walked to me, slowly, like an old man, and he put his arms round my waist and his face against my stomach, and held on.

I got down on my knees on the floor of that gym and held him. I held him so hard. He smelled of smoke and salt and something else, something burned, and his skin was cold, cold right through, even in that hot gym, and he was shaking, a little shaking all over, like a motor. His hair was stiff with salt. His back was scraped raw in long lines. He didn't make a sound.

"Baby," I said. "Baby, baby, baby." That's all I could say. I said it into his hair, a hundred times. "Baby. Baby. Mama's here. Baby."

I want to say I thought something. I didn't. There was no room in me for thinking. There was his weight, which I knew. The back of

his neck under my hand, which I knew. The little bump of bone at the top of his spine, the one I used to rub when he couldn't sleep. I went over him with my hands the way you go through a house after a storm, room by room, checking. Head. Ears. Shoulders. Arms. Fingers, all ten. I counted them. I'm not a counter. I counted them twice. Then I put my nose in his hair, under the salt and the smoke, looking for the smell of him, the real one. It took a long time. It was there.

He didn't say anything.

. . .

Bully sat down on a cot beside us, heavy, and put his face in his huge hands, and his shoulders went up and down.

When he could talk he told me. He'd gone out on his board after midnight, him and two of the young guys who surf the break off the harbor, because they'd heard there were people in the water along the seawall, and somebody had a boat outside the reef that couldn't get in over the rocks. So the surfers went in. Lay on their boards and paddled in through the gap in the reef, in the dark, in the smoke, with embers coming down, with the fire right there, and started bringing people out. Kids first. Bully took three kids out. He'd go in, take a kid on the front of his board, paddle him out to the boat, hand him up, go back in for another. The third time he went in, there was a man against the wall holding a boy, and the man gave him the boy, and Bully put his light on the boy's face, and it was Keola.

"I didn't know," Bully said. "Kanoë, I didn't know. I just saw his face. I just saw, eh, that's Kanoë's boy. That's Tūtū's boy." He wiped his face with the back of his wrist and left a clean stripe. "I yelled. I was yelling *I got him, I got him*. I was so happy, Kanoë. I was so happy."

"Where was Mom? Was Mom there?"

He looked at me. He looked down at his hands.

"I didn't see Tūtū," he said. "There was people on the wall. On the top. Some of them. I didn't—it was dark, it was smoke, I didn't look up. I was looking at the water. I'm sorry. I didn't look up."

I held my son. I didn't ask again. I knew Bully would have told me if there was anything to tell.

"Who was the man?" I said. "Holding him. Who was he?"

"Haole [HOW-leh]." *Haole* is what we call white people here. It can be rude. It can just be a description. In Bully's mouth that morning it was just a description, a tired one. "Tourist, I think. Strong. Big shoulders. He was holding Keola like this—" Bully made a shape with his arms, a cradle, one big hand flat. "All night, I think. He was crying. He kept saying thank you. Thank you, thank you." Bully stopped. Something was bothering him. I could see it in his face. "Kanoë. One thing. The man was calling him something. When I took him."

"Calling him what?"

"Another name. Not Keola. He kept saying it. Like the man thought—" Bully stopped again. He looked at my son with his face against my stomach. "He kept saying *Theo*. *Theo*, *Theo*, *you're okay*, *bud*. Like that. Like Keola was his."

I didn't understand, then, what it meant. I thought the man had been out of his mind with smoke, the way everybody had been out of their minds. I thought, he probably had a boy called Theo, and he held my son all night, in the fire, in the water, and kept him alive, and called him by his own boy's name to keep himself going. I thought: God bless him. I thought: I'll find him one day and I'll cook for him for the rest of his life.

I didn't think about the other boy. About where Theo was, if there was a Theo.

That came later. That came that evening, when the man walked into the gym.

18. Bye, Uncle

Wes

I woke up in a hospital bed in Wailuku with a tube in my nose and a needle in my arm and a nurse leaning over me saying my name.

It was the afternoon of the ninth. I'd been brought in sometime in the early morning with smoke in my lungs and my body

temperature low, and they'd given me oxygen and warm fluids and let me sleep. The nurse was young and tired and kind. Her name tag had a long Hawaiian name on it that my eyes, still stinging from the smoke, couldn't read.

"Mr. Talbert? You're in the hospital. You're okay. You breathed in a lot of smoke. You're going to be okay."

"My son."

"Okay."

"My son. Theo. Nine. Surfers took him to a boat. Where is he?"

She looked at the chart. She looked at me. "I don't know, sir. I'll find out. They've got lists at the shelters. I'll call."

She called. I heard her in the hall, on a phone, saying *Talbert, Theo, nine*, and spelling it, and then waiting, and then saying *okay*, and then *okay*, and then nothing. She came back in and said the lists weren't complete yet, a lot of the children who'd been brought out of the water were at the shelter at the civic center on the west side, and that as soon as I could stand up, someone would drive me.

I stood up. I pulled out the needle myself. The nurse said a word I won't repeat and put a cotton ball on my arm and taped it, and then, because she was kind, she found me a T-shirt and a pair of shorts from a donation box and a Red Cross volunteer with a pass who was driving supplies out to the west side.

. . .

The civic center was a big gym full of cots and smoke-smell and quiet. That's what I remember: how quiet it was. Hundreds of people and hardly a sound. People sitting on cots. People lying on cots with their arms over their eyes. Kids asleep in piles like puppies. A long whiteboard by the door covered in names. Volunteers going up and down the rows with water and rice.

I went down the rows. I looked at every child. Not him. Not him. Not him.

And then, at the end of the third row, against the far wall, there was a woman sitting on a cot, Hawaiian, about my age, in a hotel housekeeping uniform with the shirt-tail out, gray-black with ash.

She had a boy in her lap. A boy, eight or nine, curled up against her, his face in her neck, his legs folded up. She was rocking him, very slightly, forward and back. Next to her on the cot sat an enormous man with a burned-off gray ponytail, the man from the surfboard, still in his board shorts.

The boy's back was scraped in long raw lines. His hair stood up at the back like a duck's tail.

I stopped walking.

He must have felt me looking, the way children do. He turned his head on his mother's shoulder and looked across the gym at me. Dark eyes in a brown face, washed clean now. Both front teeth missing.

He looked at me for a long time. Then he lifted one hand off his mother's shoulder, a little, the way he had from the surfboard.

"Uncle," he said.

. . .

I'm going to tell you what happened inside me, and then I'm going to stop for a while, and you'll forgive me.

I understood everything at once. Not one thing after another. All of it, in a single piece, the whole night, the way you suddenly see the shape of a pool from the high board, the whole thing laid out at once in a single glance.

The bang. The wave. My arms empty. The boy who bumped into my chest in the dark, small, kicking, coughing. The boy who went soft, and lay back, and floated, calm, with his ears in the water, looking at the fire. *He finally trusts the water.* The boy who said *Uncle, my Tūtū stay on the wall?* The boy who said *Kai*. The boy who said *Bye, Uncle*.

The boy who swam better than me.

The boy whose name I hadn't known.

And somewhere back there in the black water by the rocks, after the bang, while I was screaming *Theo! Theo!*, and grabbing the first body that bumped into me, and swimming back to the wall, and holding on, and holding on, and telling myself the other boy would

be fine, because the other boy could swim, the other boy was the one who'd be fine, somewhere back there my son, who could not swim, who could not put his face in, who was afraid of what was under it, had been alone in the dark.

All night. Twenty feet away. Ten. Five. I'll never know.

I'd held the wrong boy.

I'd held the wrong boy all night, and cried over him, and told my dead wife to look at him, and smiled when he waved goodbye to me.

I stood in the middle of that gym and did what I always do. I measured. Waist deep at the rock. Chest deep where the wave threw me. Past the end of the rocks, more than I could touch, and then the reef, and then the channel, and then the blue that goes down. The first thing they teach you at every lifeguard training is that drowning is quiet. It doesn't splash. It doesn't shout. It looks like nothing. I'd been shouting his name into the dark, and he'd have been somewhere in that dark, quiet, and I'd have been listening for the wrong sound. I did the sums standing there with my hands open at my sides, and they came out the same every time, and there was nobody to hand them to.

. . .

The woman was looking at me now. Over the boy's head. She'd seen her son speak to me, and she'd seen my face, and she was putting it together, the way I'd put it together, a second behind me.

The big man stood up off the cot. "That's him," he said to her quietly. "That's the guy. That's the guy was holding him."

She looked at me. I'll never forget her face. It was full of the most complicated thing I've ever seen on a human face: gratitude and horror and pity and grief, all at once, all of it real, none of it canceling the others out.

"You," she said. "You held my son."

I said, "Where's mine?"

I said it to her as if she would know. As if she'd have him. As if it were a mix-up at the coat check, and she'd reach behind the cot and

bring out the right one, a little thin boy with his mother's dark curls, and say *Sorry, here you go*.

She didn't say anything. She couldn't. She just held her boy tighter and looked at me with that face.

I turned around. I walked out. I don't remember walking out. I remember the parking lot, the hot asphalt, the sky still brown with smoke, and that I was walking south, along the highway, toward the town, toward the seawall, toward the water, and that it was a long way, and that somebody, a policeman, a young one with red eyes, stopped me at the roadblock and put his hand up flat, and said, "Sir, nobody's going in," and I said, "My son is in there," and he said, "I'm sorry," and I said, "My son is *nine*," and he said, "Sir, I've got a kid too," and I sat down in the middle of the highway, and I didn't get up for a long time.

19. The List

Kanoe

In the days after, there was a list.

You might have heard about it. For a while, the whole world heard about it. It was a list of the people nobody could find. The *unaccounted for*, they called them, which is a phrase that sounds like bookkeeping, like a column of numbers that won't add up. At the start it was more than a thousand names. A thousand people somebody had reported missing and nobody had found. Then, day by day, people were found: in shelters, at cousins' houses on the other side of the island, on planes to Honolulu, in hospitals, asleep on a friend's couch with a dead phone. Their names came off the list. And other names came off for the other reason.

I went to the place where they took the swabs. That's how they found out who the dead were, the ones the fire hadn't left enough of to know by their faces. They took DNA. They scraped the inside of your cheek with a long cotton swab, like a giant Q-tip, gently, both sides, and they put the swab in a little tube with a label, and they used it to match you against what they found. A family member gives a swab, and if your family member is among the dead, the swab will say so. It takes weeks. You go home and you wait.

I gave my swab for my mother.

A woman in a white mask and a blue paper gown did it. She was very kind. She said *open, please, and this won't hurt, and thank you*, and when it was done she put her gloved hand on my shoulder for a second and didn't say anything. There was a line of people behind me. A long line. Old people, young people, people holding photos. A man in front of me in the line had given four swabs. Four. I saw him. He walked out holding the little cards they gave you like a hand of poker that had lost.

. . .

They told me about my mother on the eighteenth of August. They'd found her days before. It took that long for the swab to match.

They found her on top of the seawall on Front Street. Sitting, the man from the county said, very gently, standing in the doorway of the hotel room. Sitting up. Facing the sea. He didn't say anything else about it and I didn't ask. Later I learned that a lot of the people who died were found in their cars on Front Street, in the jam, trying to get out, and some in their houses, and some near the water. Most of them were old. That's the thing nobody says enough. Most of the people who died in Lahaina were old, older than sixty, the people who couldn't run, who couldn't climb walls, who'd never in their lives gone past their knees.

My mother was sitting on the wall above the place where a stranger had held her grandson in the water all night.

She'd stayed. She'd stayed on the wall. Right there. Above him. I knew why. I didn't know yet how I knew. I just knew.

She couldn't swim. She couldn't climb down. She couldn't see him in the dark, not once, not all night. So she did the one thing that was left to a woman with bad ankles and a voice that could reach the end of the lane. She sat where he could find her. Like a porch light you leave on. Like that plastic chair on the lanai every afternoon, when he came up the lane from the harbor dripping and late, and she shouted at him, and he knew from the shouting that he was home. She kept her place. That's all. She kept her place all night, so that if he looked up, there would be somebody there.

When the man from the county left I closed the door and sat down on the hotel carpet with my back against the door and put my face into my knees, and I made a sound I'd never made before, a sound that came up from somewhere under my stomach, and I couldn't stop it. My son was asleep on the bed. He didn't wake up. Or he woke up and didn't move. I'll never know which.

. . .

The hotel. I should tell you about the hotel.

After the fire there were thousands of us with nowhere to live. Eight, ten thousand people, they said, whose homes were gone. And the island had hotels. Big, beautiful, empty hotels, because the tourists had all left. So the Red Cross and the government paid the hotels to take us in. That was the plan, and it was a good plan, I'm not saying it wasn't. We got a room. Clean sheets. A shower. A view of the ocean.

They put us in a resort in Kā'anapali.

They put us in *my* resort. The one where I worked. Same building. Same tower. Same long hallways with the same patterned carpet I'd vacuumed ten thousand times. We were on the fourth floor. A garden-view king. I knew that room. I'd cleaned that room. I knew which drawer stuck and which light switch was backward.

And two weeks after the fire, they called me back to work. Same job. The resort needed housekeepers, and I needed money, and the rooms were full of families like mine, and somebody had to clean them.

So that's what I did. For months. In the morning I got up in a hotel room, and dressed my silent son, and took him to the room downstairs where volunteers watched the kids, and then I went to the laundry and got my cart, my own cart, with my name still taped on the handle, and I went up the stairs and cleaned the rooms of people who'd lost their homes in the same fire as me, and they left me five dollars on the pillow, some of them, which was one of the worst things that happened to me that year, and I took it.

. . .

Keola didn't speak.

Not in the hotel. Not in the playroom with the volunteers. Not to me. He'd nod. He'd shake his head. He'd eat a little, if I put food in front of him and sat there. He'd let me hold him. At night he'd sleep pressed against my back so hard I could feel the bones of his face against my spine. But no words came out of him, not one, not for weeks, and then not for months. The only word he'd said since the fire was the one he said to that man in the gym: *Uncle*. A doctor came, a woman who works with children after terrible things. She sat on the floor with him and some crayons. She told me afterward that it happens, that children sometimes go quiet when what's inside them is too big to say, that it's a way of holding very still till the danger passes. That he'd speak when he was ready. That I shouldn't push.

I didn't push. I'm not much of a pusher. I just waited, and cleaned rooms, and every night I lay in that bed I used to make and listened to him breathing, and I thought about the haole man in the gym, his face when he understood. *Where's mine?*

I thought about his boy, whose name I knew. Theo. Theo, Theo, you're okay, bud.

I found out later that the name was on the list, near the end, under T. *Talbert, Theo, 9, visitor, Ohio*. For weeks it was there. Then they took the list down. They said there were only a few names left, and they'd keep looking. Then there were fewer. Then the names that were left, they stopped saying out loud.

They never found him. I'll say that now, plainly, so you don't wait for it. The sea didn't give him back.

20. The Weight

Wes

I stayed on Maui three weeks.

I don't know how to tell you about those weeks, so here is what I did.

I gave them my cheek. They swabbed it, both sides, so they could match me against whatever they found. I stood at the edge of the burn zone every day, at the fence they'd put up, at the line of police

tape, and I watched the men in white suits and masks go in with their dogs. The dogs were trained to find people. That's all I'll say about the dogs. I talked to the Coast Guard. A lieutenant with a kind, square face sat with me on a bench at the harbor up the coast and told me, without hurrying, what the currents do along that coast. How the wind that night was blowing straight out to sea. How anything in the water near the wall would have been carried out, through the gaps in the reef, into the channel. How the channel there is very deep. He used that word. Deep. He said they'd searched. He said they'd keep looking. He said he was sorry, and he meant it, I could tell. He'd said it before. He'd say it again that week. He was still saying it with care. I liked him for that.

I went to the hotel where they were putting up the visitors who'd lost everything, and I slept there, or didn't sleep. They gave me a room with a view of the channel. I sat on the lanai at night and looked at the black water and the lights of Lāna'i across it and I thought: he's out there. Somewhere out there, between here and there. In the deep part.

Will she be scared? In the deep part?

. . .

I found out about Claire on the ninth day.

That's how I think about it, even now: *I found out about Claire*. As if she were a fact I'd learned, like the depth of the channel. I was in the hotel room, going through what I had left, which was nothing: the borrowed T-shirt, the donated shorts, and the backpack. The firefighters had peeled it off me on the street that night and somebody had put it in a plastic bag with my name on it, and the bag had followed me to the hospital and back, and I hadn't looked at it. That day I took it out and looked.

The long gash down the side. The strap half torn off. Empty. Wallet, phone, water, inhaler, gone. And the inside of the bag, all the inside of the bag, every seam and corner, the bottom, the zipper teeth, was coated with a fine pale gray powder. Dried now. Not ash. I knew ash by then, I'd had it in my hair and teeth for a week. This was different. Finer. Paler. Grittier. Like the finest sand.

I sat on the floor of that hotel room with the bag in my lap and rubbed a little of it between my fingers, and I remembered the water that night. The pale cloud that came and went around us with the waves. The haze in the water. The flour-fine dust on my arms and on the boy's chest when I looked down. *Ash*, I'd thought. *That's the town*.

She'd gone in. The bag had torn in the rocks, in the blast, and the inner bag with it, and she'd gone into the water. All five pounds of her. Not from a boat. Not in the channel where we'd seen the whales. Not on a calm blue morning with Theo holding my hand and the two of us saying something we'd written down beforehand. At the bottom of a seawall in a burning town, in the dark, in the smoke, while I held a stranger's child.

The same night as him. The same water.

I sat there a long time with the gray on my fingertips. I didn't wipe it off. I want to be careful how I say this, because it isn't a pretty thing and I won't make it one. It was the last of her that wasn't in the sea: a little dust in the seams of a torn bag. They had gone into the water together, the two of them, within the same minute, and I had been there, an arm's length away, and I hadn't known. I had put my hand in her and called it ash. I had watched her slide off my fingers and thought, *that's the town*. The afternoon light went across the carpet while I sat there, and up the far side of the room, and off it, and I didn't get up to turn on the lamp.

I'd promised her somewhere warm.

. . .

I don't want to tell you about the flight home, so I won't. I'll tell you only that I flew back alone, and that the airline, when I told them at the check-in desk why there was only one of us, gave me a seat with nobody next to me, and that I sat in that row and looked out the window as the plane came up over the channel, and I saw the water from above again. The palest green near the shore, then the bright turquoise, then the bruise-dark patches of the reef, and then, all at once, as if somebody had drawn it with a ruler, the deep.

The deep blue. The blue that went *down*.

I put my hand flat on the window, like a kid.

I didn't say anything. There was nobody to say it to. But in my head, very clearly, in my own voice, I heard myself say, *Theo, look*. Just that. *Theo, look*. And then the plane turned, and the island went under the wing, and was gone.

21. We Buy Lahaina

Kanoe

The texts started coming before the fire was fully out.

Not just to me. To everybody. I'd be in the hotel room, or in the laundry, or at the shelter picking up diapers for my cousin's baby, and my phone would buzz, and it would be a number I didn't know.

Aloha, so sorry for your loss. We are local investors interested in purchasing your Lahaina property, any condition, cash, fast close. Call anytime.

Aloha [ah-LOH-hah] is our hello and our goodbye and our love, all in one word. They used it to sell.

Hi! Saw your property on Lahainaluna. We buy as-is. No repairs needed.

As-is. My house was ash. As-is.

Lahaina Strong! Let us take the stress away. We pay cash for land.

I'd never told anybody my phone number except family and work and the dentist. They had it anyway. Everybody's. You could find anyone's name and address and phone number from the county property records in about five minutes, somebody explained to me later, if you knew how and had the motivation. Somebody had the motivation. Somebody was sitting somewhere going down a list of burned addresses, address by address, with a cup of coffee, texting widows.

I didn't answer. Nobody I knew answered. Bully wrote back to one of them, from the next room in the hotel, a long text with a lot of words in it I won't repeat. He showed it to me afterward. It was very creative.

The Governor went on TV a week or so after the fire and said he was going to try to stop it. He said he'd look for a way to put a pause on land sales in Lahaina, so that families wouldn't be pressured to sell to outsiders while they were still grieving. He said, more or less, *Lahaina will remain in Hawaiian hands*. I watched it on the hotel TV, sitting on the edge of the bed I used to make. I wanted to believe him. I think he meant it. I don't think he could do it. You can't stop people selling their own land if they want to, it turns out. Not for long. Not legally. And a lot of people would want to. A lot of people had a mortgage on a house that was gone, and no job, and the rent somewhere else on the island was already more than they'd ever paid. A lot of people would get tired. That's what the texts were waiting for. They weren't in a hurry. They had all the time in the world. They just needed you to get tired.

. . .

In October they reopened West Maui to tourists.

The Governor said it had to happen. He said it on TV again, and he wasn't wrong, exactly. Tourism is the island's work. It's most of the jobs. Everybody I knew, my cousins, the boys from the activity desk, Bully's nephew who drove a tour van, all of them needed the tourists back, needed the paycheck, needed the five dollars on the pillow. So the hotels started taking visitors again, a little at a time, starting at the far north end and working down.

And so there were mornings, that autumn, when I would walk out of the hotel lobby with my son to take him to the school they'd set up for the Lahaina kids in a borrowed building, and in the lobby there'd be a family just arriving, with suitcases and sunburn and leis [LAYZ], necklaces of flowers, round their necks, sweet and fresh, being welcomed by the front desk girl, who was my second cousin, and whose house was also gone. And the family would step aside to let us by, politely. And they would not know. There was no reason they'd know. We looked like anybody.

Some of us went to the beach. You might have seen that too. People from Lahaina set up chairs and coolers and fishing poles on the beach in front of the big Kā'anapali hotels, right on the sand, and stayed there. Every day. For months. They called it a *fish-in*. They

were fishing, sort of, but they were really sitting. Sitting where the tourists could see them, holding signs, saying in the most polite way possible: *we're still here. We're your housekeepers and your cooks and your bus drivers and we're living in your hotel and we have nowhere to go.* They wanted the government to do something about the vacation rentals, the thousands of apartments and houses on the island that were rented to tourists by the week instead of to families by the year, because if those went back to families, there'd be somewhere for us to live.

There's a word we have, *kuleana* [koo-leh-AH-nah]. It means responsibility, but it also means the right that comes with it, both at once, like two sides of one coin. If the land feeds you, you have the kuleana to care for it, and you also have the right to stay on it. That's what the people on the beach were saying, really. Not *give us something*. Just: this is our kuleana. We're not going anywhere.

I went once. I sat on a cooler next to an old man with a fishing pole with no hook on it, and we looked out at the water together, and a woman in a big hat walked past us with her husband and said, not unkindly, "Oh, look, honey, the locals are fishing," and he said, "Isn't that nice."

...

They let us go back to see the houses in October. Not to stay. To look. You had to make an appointment and go in a group, and they gave you a white suit made of paper, with a hood, and gloves and booties and a mask, because the ash was full of poisons. Old paint, old pipes, the chemicals they'd put on the cane a hundred years ago, the batteries from all the cars. All of it burned together and lying there in a gray powder a foot deep.

I took Keola. I don't know if that was right. The doctor said I could, if he wanted. I asked him if he wanted to and he nodded.

We walked up the lane in our white suits, holding hands. It was like walking on the moon. Everything gray. Everything flat. You could see straight through to the mountain from the sea, because there was nothing left standing in between. Just the black trunks of trees, here and there, and the chimneys of a few houses that had them,

and car frames, rusted orange already, and twisted metal, and the gray.

The lane wasn't a lane. It was a gray place with shapes in it. I found our house by the concrete steps. Three steps going up to nothing. And the slab the house had stood on, covered in ash and broken glass and black curls of melted tin from the roof.

In the corner where the kitchen had been there was the rice cooker. Black. Melted on one side. Its lid fused shut. It was sitting there on the slab where the counter used to be, upright, like it was waiting for someone to push the button.

I'd left my note under it. The morning of the fire. *No power. Went work. Charge phone in car if you need. Love you.*

I stood there looking at that rice cooker and something broke in me that I won't describe, and I let it break, and I stood there in my white paper suit in the middle of what used to be my house and cried until the mask was wet through. Keola stood next to me and held my gloved hand and didn't say anything. He was looking at something.

He was looking at the gate. Where the gate had been.

The angel's trumpet tree was dead. Burned down to a black stump, just a jagged stick of charcoal knee-high. But at the base of it, out of the black, out of the gray, there was something green. Three leaves. Big, soft, new, pale green, the size of my hand. Pushing up out of the burned root.

Keola let go of my hand and went over and crouched down in front of it, in his little white suit, the paper rustling, and he looked at those three leaves for a long time. And he didn't touch them. He knew better. Every bit of it is poison. Tūtū told him that the first day he could walk to the gate.

I watched him from the slab. A little white paper boy crouched in a gray world, not touching. He put his gloved hands on his knees to keep them still. He looked at those leaves the way he'd looked up at that tree when he was three, mouth shut tight, for a long time, like they might reach down and get him. And I thought: she's still

teaching him. Even now. Even burned down to a stick. Here is a pretty thing. Here is what it can do. Don't touch. Remember.

Somebody has to remember what pretty things can do.

22. Three in the Morning

Wes

The pool at my school in Ohio is lit from under the water. You come in at five-thirty on a winter morning before practice, when it's still black outside and snowing, and you don't turn on the overhead lights yet, and the water is glowing, a clear blue light coming up out of it, throwing wobbling ripples of light onto the ceiling. I used to love that. I used to stand in the doorway with my coffee for a minute, before the kids came, and watch the light move on the ceiling, and feel lucky to have a job where that was the first thing I saw every day.

I went back to work in October. The school was very kind. Everybody was very kind. My kids, my swimmers, sixteen- and seventeen-year-olds, made a banner and hung it on the wall of the pool, a long white bedsheet with blue letters: *WE LOVE YOU COACH*. Underneath it somebody had painted a little blue wave. They'd all signed it. I stood in front of it on my first morning back and couldn't move.

I could coach. I could stand on the deck and blow the whistle and call out times and tell a girl to tuck her chin on the turn. I was good at it. I was still good at it.

I couldn't get in.

Every time I stood at the edge, at the deep end, and looked down at the water, at the black line on the bottom twelve feet down, wobbling in the light, I felt it in the backs of my knees, the way you feel a high place. *I can't see what's under it.* And I'd step back, and go and stand somewhere else.

. . .

At night I read.

I don't sleep much now. I wake up at three, most nights, the same time every night, as if something is setting an alarm in me. I used to

lie there. Now I get up and go downstairs and sit at the kitchen table with my laptop, in the dark, with the snow falling outside the window over the back porch where Claire used to stand in thunderstorms, and I read about the fire. Everything. Every report, every timeline, every article, every interview with every survivor. Over that winter and the year after, I read the official investigations as they came out, what the fire scientists said and what the government's investigators said. I've read what the power company said and what the lawyers suing the power company said.

And I've read the other things. The things people put on the internet at three in the morning.

You know some of them. Everybody does. That the fire was set on purpose. That it was started from space, by a laser, a secret weapon, and they'll show you pictures of a beam of light coming down from the sky that is, if you look at it for a second with a clear head, a picture of something else entirely, an old photo from a rocket launch or a transformer blowing up somewhere far away. That everything blue survived, blue cars, blue roofs, blue umbrellas, because the laser couldn't burn blue. That it was all a plan to clear the land and build some kind of computer-run city. That the death toll was really thousands and they were hiding the bodies, all the children, especially the children.

I've looked and looked, and there's nothing in those. The pictures are other pictures. The blue things didn't survive because they were blue; plenty of blue things burned, and the things that didn't burn, didn't burn for ordinary reasons, a metal roof, a gap between the house and the next one, a wind that turned. The death toll, by the end, was a hundred and two, every one of them counted by name. The few who were never found, like my son, were kept on a separate list. I know because I watched them keep him on it.

But I understand why people believe it. Because at three in the morning, a laser from space is easier. A laser from space means somebody did it on purpose, somebody evil, somebody you can hate with your whole heart. It means it was a plan. A plan is better than what really happened. What really happened is that nobody planned anything. A power line came down in the wind onto dry grass, and the grass was there because the sugar left and nobody cut it, and

the hydrants ran dry, and the sirens didn't sound, and the phones didn't work, and the fire that was out wasn't out, and a hundred small things went wrong one after another, each one ordinary, each one somebody's ordinary mistake on an ordinary bad day, and they all added up, and my son is at the bottom of the channel.

There's no one to hate for that. That's what's unbearable. You can't hate *a hundred small things*.

So some people make one big thing out of them, so they'll have someone to hate. I understand that.

I don't do it. I'd like to say it's because I'm too smart. It isn't. It's because I'm a coach, and I know what it's like when a kid drowns in a pool. I've never had it happen. Thank God. But I've been to the trainings, a dozen of them, and they all say the same thing: it's never one thing. It's never a monster. It's the lifeguard looking away for nine seconds to answer a question, and the pool being a little too crowded, and the kid's friend saying *come on, it's not that deep*. It's always a hundred small things.

I know about a hundred small things. I held the wrong boy.

...

Some of what people said, I couldn't dismiss. Here it is, in a row.

That the power company didn't switch off the lines. That's true. The company that runs the electricity on Maui didn't have a plan for shutting off power ahead of a dangerous wind, the way the big power companies in California do now. They knew the wind was coming. The weather people had said so for days. They left the lines on. The lines came down on the grass. The lawyers say that's why. The company says its lines had been switched off for hours by the time the afternoon fire started, and that the afternoon fire was the morning fire coming back to life, which is what the investigators finally said too. Both of those things can be true. The morning fire was theirs. And the afternoon fire was the morning fire.

That the power company had talked for years about making its lines safer against fire, about stronger poles and covered wires and cutting back the brush, and that most of that work hadn't been done. That's true too. You can read about it.

That the water was held up. That a man asked for stream water for the reservoirs on the day of the fire and was told to wait. That's true. Whether it would have mattered, nobody knows.

That the sirens were silent. True. That the man who could have sounded them said he was afraid people would run toward the fire. True. That he quit nine days later. True.

That somebody started texting people offering to buy their burned land within days. True. I've seen the texts. A woman I know sent me pictures of them.

None of that's a laser. None of it's a plan. All of it's real. You can put it in a row and look at it and decide for yourself what kind of thing it is. Whether it's a hundred small things, or something more.

I don't know. I've looked at it every night for months.

The woman I know is Kanoë. I should tell you that. She sent me a letter in November. The first one. Handwritten, on hotel notepaper, with the hotel's name at the top. She'll tell you about it herself.

I'm still sitting here. It's three in the morning. It's snowing.

23. What Tūtū Did

Kanoë

Keola spoke on the twenty-fourth of November. The day after Thanksgiving.

We'd had Thanksgiving in a ballroom. The hotel had put on a big dinner for all the fire families living there, turkey and stuffing and *kālua* [KAH-loo-ah] pig, which is pork cooked slow in an underground oven, and rice, and mac salad, which is macaroni in mayonnaise, and poi. Hundreds of us, at long tables with white cloths, under chandeliers. Some people sang. Some people cried. Everybody ate too much because nobody knew what else to do with their hands. Keola ate two plates and fell asleep with his head on the table, and Bully carried him upstairs.

The next morning I woke up early. It was still dark. I was lying on my side facing the window with Keola against my back, the way he always slept, his face pressed to my spine. And I felt him wake up. I felt his breathing change.

And then he said, into my back, very quietly, in a voice that cracked from not being used:

“Mama. Tūtū gave me to Uncle.”

His voice was different. Lower, rough, with the whistle still in it where his teeth were gone. Three months I’d waited for it. I’d lain in that bed every night listening to him breathe and trying to remember exactly how he sounded, and I was starting to lose it, the way you lose a song you haven’t heard in a long time. And here it was, against my spine, in the dark. I felt the words before I heard them. They came through his chest into my back.

I didn’t move. I didn’t turn around. I was afraid if I turned around he’d stop. I held still the way you hold still when a bird lands near you. I lay there with my heart going and the dark window in front of me and I said, as gently as I could, “Tell me, baby.”

And he told me.

. . .

He told me how the fire came down the lane. How Tūtū was in the kitchen and he was in the yard with his ball and the smoke came over the roof all at once, black, and there was fire in Uncle Bully’s mango tree three houses down, and Tūtū came out on the lanai and looked, just for a second, and said, “Keola. Shoes. *Now.*” And he didn’t even get his shoes. He went in his bare feet. How she took his hand and they went out the gate, past the angel’s trumpet, and she said, “Makai. We go makai. To the water. The water always goes home and so do we.”

He told me how they walked down the hill toward the sea. How she couldn’t go fast. How the fire was in the trees on both sides and the wind was full of burning leaves and Tūtū kept her free hand over his head the whole way down, like an umbrella, and burning leaves landed on her arm and she just brushed them off and kept walking. How there were cars in the street not moving, people screaming, and a man on the corner of Front Street with a garden hose spraying it in the air like it would help.

He told me about the wall. The haole Uncle with the boy around his neck. The boy who was screaming *I can’t, I can’t*. He said, “It was

the scared boy, Mama. From the harbor. The one who wouldn't swim. I told him the water was nice."

He told me what Tūtū said. He told me exactly. He was eight and he'd been carrying it in his mouth for three months, shut tight, so he had it exactly.

You hold him. You don't let go. Whatever.

Go with Uncle. I'll be right here. I'll be right here on the wall.

Take my life.

I lay there with my eyes open in the dark and the tears running sideways off my nose onto the pillow, and I understood what my mother had said. What she'd meant. Not *my life is over*. Not *save yourself*. She'd handed my son to a stranger and told him the boy's name in words the stranger couldn't know were a name.

Keola. *The life*. She'd said, *take my life*. She'd said, *take Keola*.

She'd said *my life*. The way she always did. *Good night, my life*.

. . .

He told me the rest. How they went in the water. How it hit them. How he held Uncle's backpack strap, and how the other boy, the scared boy, was holding Uncle's neck and crying, and how Uncle kept counting, out loud, *one, two, three, here it comes, hold*, and how Uncle had a nice voice for counting.

He told me about the bang.

"It was so loud, Mama. It was like the whole world. And the wave came and I went under and I let go of the backpack and I was rolling and rolling and then I came up and I couldn't see nothing. Smoke. And I heard Uncle yelling. *Theo! Theo!* So I swam to Uncle. Because he was yelling. And I bumped into him and he grabbed me."

"And he thought you were Theo."

"Yeah." A long silence. His breath on my back. "He said *I got you, bud*. He was crying. He was holding me so tight. And I knew I wasn't Theo, Mama. I knew. But he was crying and I didn't want him to stop holding me."

"Oh, baby."

"So I didn't say."

. . .

I waited. I could feel there was more. I could feel it in his breathing, the way he was holding still, the way you hold still on top of a wave before it breaks.

"Mama."

"Yes, baby."

"After the bang. When I came up. When I was swimming to Uncle." His voice went very small. "I heard the other boy."

I didn't say anything. I couldn't.

"He was yelling Dad. *Dad, Dad*. By the rocks. In the smoke. I couldn't see him. I heard him." A long silence. "Then the wave came again. And I didn't hear him."

He was crying now. Finally, after three months, he was crying, against my back, big ugly sobs that shook the whole bed, and I turned over at last and held him against my chest, my son, my life, and he said into me, over and over, "I didn't say, Mama, I didn't tell Uncle, I didn't say," and I said, "It's not yours, baby, it's not yours, it's not your fault, you were eight, you were in the water, it's not yours," and I held him until the window went gray and then gold and the sun came up over the black mountain.

. . .

After he slept I got up and took the hotel notepad from the desk, with the hotel's name across the top in gold, and the hotel pen, and I sat on the floor by the window and I wrote a letter to the haole man.

I knew his name by then. Talbert. Everybody in the shelters knew it. The man from Ohio who lost his son at the seawall. I got his address from a woman at the family center who probably shouldn't have given it to me.

I wrote down everything Keola told me. All of it. I didn't make it nicer. I thought he'd want to know. I thought, if it were me, I'd want

to know every single thing, even the worst thing, *especially* the worst thing, because the worst thing I can imagine is always worse than the worst thing that happened.

I told him what my mother said on the wall. I told him what it meant. I told him my son's name.

At the end I wrote: *I'm sorry. I'm sorry about Theo. Keola says he was a nice boy. Keola says he wanted to see the deep part, for his mother. He whispered it to Keola in the water, before the bang, between the waves, while you were counting. I'm sorry about your wife too. Keola says the scared boy told him his mom was in your bag.*

My mother stayed on the wall all night above you. They found her there. I think she was singing. I think you heard her. I think she was singing to both boys.

You held my son. I don't know what to say about that. I'm grateful. I'm so angry. I'm sorry. I don't know which one is true. All of them, I think.

Thank you. — Kanoë

I put it in an envelope from the front desk and gave it to my second cousin, who was working the desk that morning, and she put a stamp on it and didn't ask me anything.

Said in the Harbor

Let me tell you what they'll do now, up there. I know because I've seen it before. Not here, maybe. Not this town. But it always goes the same way, everywhere, every time a town burns or floods or falls into me. It goes like a tide. You can set your watch by it.

First they'll ask who did it.

That's right. That's what they should ask. And some of the answers will be plain and some will be crooked, and they'll come out slowly, over months, over years, in reports with long names. They'll say the power lines did it. A line came down in the wind onto the grass in the morning, they'll say, and sparked, and they'll say the fire that came back in the afternoon was the same fire, not out, only sleeping. They'll find that the company that ran the lines had no

plan to turn them off in a bad wind, though other companies in other places did. They'll find that the company had talked for years about making its lines safer against fire, and that most of the work was still waiting. They'll find the company had paid its owners their share every year while the safety work waited. Some will say these are the same fact. Some will say they aren't.

They'll find that the grass was there because the sugar left and nobody tended the land after, and that people had warned about that grass for years, at meeting after meeting, and the grass grew back taller after every meeting.

They'll find that the sirens were silent, and that the man in charge of them said he feared they'd send people running uphill, into the fire. Some will believe him. Some will say a siren is a siren, and a frightened person can be told which way to run.

They'll find the hydrants went soft. They'll find the pipes melted in the houses and I ran out through the broken ends onto the ground. They'll find that on the day of the fire, a request to put more of me into the reservoirs waited for hours on a desk. They'll argue for years about whether that mattered. Some will say it couldn't have. Some will say: then why did you make him wait?

They'll find that some roads were blocked, by fallen poles and live wires, and by crews and officers turning cars back from those wires, and that people sat in their cars on Front Street with the fire coming because there was nowhere to turn. Some will say: they were keeping people from being electrocuted. Some will say: they kept us in. Both of them were there. Both of them saw what they saw.

Then they'll ask who pays.

And that will take a long time, and it will be lawyers, and it will be numbers so large they stop sounding like money. In the end, the power company and the landowners and the county and the state and others will agree together to pay something over four billion dollars to the people who lost everything, and none of them will admit that they did anything wrong, which is how such agreements are written. Then the insurance companies will go to court and argue about who gets to take what out of it, because they paid too,

for the houses, and they'll want their money back. Ordinary people will wait in hotel rooms while this happens.

Then they'll ask who gets the land.

They'll text the widows. They'll call the old men. *Cash. Fast. As-is.* The Governor will say *no one should be pressured to sell*, and he'll mean it, and it will help a little and not enough. Somebody will remember that the land under that town was taken once already, a hundred and fifty years ago, piece by piece, by the sugar men, and the water with it. Somebody will look at the burned lots by the sea, the best land on the island, with its view of the channel, cleared now, flat, ready, and they will say out loud the thing a lot of people are thinking. *Isn't this convenient. Isn't it convenient for somebody.*

That's the strongest of the stories they'll tell. I want you to look at it closely.

Here's what's real in it: the lots will be worth a great deal. People with money will want them. Some families will sell, because they're tired, because the rent somewhere else is more than they ever paid, because the insurance won't cover what it costs to rebuild now. In the years after, the island will have to fight hard, in law after law, to keep the town for the people who were born in it. And the fight will be real, and not all of it will be won.

Here's what isn't in it, as far as anyone has found: a hand that lit the match. A meeting where somebody said *burn it*. No one has ever found that. Many have looked.

So you'll have to decide, the way every person on this island will have to decide. Was it a plan? Or was it something worse than a plan? A plan, at least, is somebody's. Something worse is no one's. A hundred small hungers, each of them ordinary, each one sure it had a good reason, all of them leaning the same way, downhill, like water. That's what I'd tell you, if you asked me. But you're right not to take my word. I'm not neutral. I was taken too.

And then there'll be the other stories. You'll hear them. The ones about lights from the sky and secret weapons, about blue things that couldn't burn, about cities run by machines, about thousands of hidden dead. I'll say this about them once and then leave them in the dark where they belong: they aren't true, and the people who

need them most aren't stupid. They're grieving. They'd rather have a monster than a hundred small things. A monster you can fight.

I'm not a monster. Neither was the fire. Neither was the wind. We only did what we do. It's people who choose. Who gets the water. Who gets the land. Who gets told to wait, and who doesn't.

The tide goes out. The tide comes in. The questions will go on longer than any of the people asking them.

I'll be here for the answer, whenever it comes. I have nowhere else to be.

V. THE FLOAT

24. One Year

Wes

I came back on the sixth of August, a year later, almost to the day.

I came in on the same approach. I'd asked for a window seat on the left side. The woman at the desk in Ohio didn't ask why. The plane came down out of the high white clouds over the channel, and there it was, the water, all its colors laid out below me like a map somebody had painted by hand. Pale green, bright turquoise, the dark bruises of the reef, and the ruled line where the bottom falls away and the blue goes down.

I didn't put my hand on the window this time. I'd decided I wouldn't. I just looked. I looked at the deep part for as long as the plane let me, the whole long slow turn in over the island, and I thought about a lieutenant with a square kind face on a bench at a harbor, saying *deep*, and meaning it carefully.

. . .

I didn't stay in Lahaina. You couldn't. Most of it was still behind fences. I stayed up the coast in a small, cheap hotel with a view of a parking lot, and on the seventh I drove down and parked as close as I could get and walked along the fences.

I'm going to tell you what it looked like a year later, since I've told you what it looked like before, and during.

It was clean. That's what struck me first. A year of work by thousands of people in white suits and hard hats, with trucks and machines, had taken away the ash and the rubble and the burned cars. The town wasn't gray anymore. It was brown. Lot after lot of bare, scraped, packed brown dirt, each one marked off at its corners with little stakes and orange ribbon, each one with a concrete slab or a set of steps or just nothing, and between them the streets, swept, empty, with grass already pushing up in the cracks. Here and there a stone wall. A single chimney. The black trunk of a tree with no branches, standing like a post. On some of the lots people had put up things: a cross made of two burned beams, a painted sign that said *WE WILL RETURN*, a ring of white stones with a plastic lei on it, a child's bicycle painted all over in

bright flowers. On one lot somebody had planted a single banana tree, already taller than me, its big leaves shining.

You could see from the mountain to the sea. Nothing was in the way. From the fence at the top of the town you could look straight down Lahainaluna Road, a mile of brown dirt and stakes and ribbon, all the way to the blue water at the bottom, and Lānaʻi floating there across the channel exactly as it had floated for a million years. It was the most beautiful view in the world. It had been, all along, hidden behind a town.

. . .

The banyan was alive.

I'd heard. Everybody had heard. It had been in the news all year, the tree that survived. But I hadn't believed it until I stood in front of it. It was fenced, and propped, and there were hoses running in among the roots, and somebody had built little shade screens around some of the trunks. Half of it was still black, the bark scorched, the hanging roots burned off short. But all through the top of it, all over the old gray arms, there were leaves. Green leaves. Not many, not the great roaring crown I'd stood under with my son in the wind. Patches. Tufts. Bright, new, shining, the green of the inside of a cucumber, coming out of black wood.

I stood at the fence. An old man was standing there too, a local man, with a cane and a straw hat. He didn't look at me. He said, after a while, to the tree, "Still here."

"Yeah," I said.

"They said it was going to die." He nodded at it. "Tree don't listen."

. . .

I walked down to the seawall last.

Most of Front Street was still fenced. But for the anniversary they'd opened a stretch of the seawall where people could come, with a gap in the fence and a volunteer at a folding table. I found the stretch. I knew it. I don't know how. Everything was different, the buildings across the road gone, just brown lots and orange ribbon where the T-shirt shop had been. But the wall was the same wall. The same concrete, waist-high, with the flat top. The same black

rocks below it. The same water coming in on the rocks, green and gold in the afternoon light, slapping and sucking, gentle, ordinary, as if nothing had ever happened here.

People had left things on the wall. All along it. Flowers, dried and fresh. Leis, dozens of them, hung over the edge. Stones with names painted on them. Candles in jars, burned out. Photos in plastic sleeves, faded by a year of sun. A pair of rubber slippers, men's slippers, side by side, very neat, with a white flower in each one.

I stood in front of those slippers for a long time.

Then I took out of my pocket the thing I'd brought. It was a pair of swim goggles. Kid's goggles, blue, with a strap that had been knotted to make it shorter. Theo's. The pair he'd never once put on over his eyes at the Y, the pair I'd packed for Hawaii in case. He'd left them on the back seat of the rental car after the beach on Friday. The apartment was gone. But the rental car had been in the lot six blocks north, and the lot hadn't burned. Of all the things. Of all the things in that whole town, a parking lot. The rental company found the goggles on the back seat and mailed them to Ohio in October, in a padded envelope, with a note saying they were sorry for my loss and had waived all fees.

I put the goggles on the wall, next to the slippers. I sat down on the wall with my legs over the sea, where the old woman had sat. And I didn't say anything to anybody, because there was nobody to say it to, and I looked at the water.

25. Take My Life

Kanoe

We'd been writing letters all year. Not many. Five or six, each way. His were typed and short and very careful, like he was afraid of using too many words. Mine were on whatever paper I had. When the hotel moved us out in the spring, into an apartment an hour away on the other side of the island, three rooms, nothing on the walls, rented through some program the state set up, I wrote him on the back of the moving forms.

He wrote me in July that he was coming back for the anniversary. He asked if he could see Keola. He said he'd understand if not.

I asked Keola. He was nine by then. He'd grown two inches and his new front teeth had come in, big and crooked. He talked now. Not like before. He'd never be the boy who screamed off the harbor wall again. But he talked. He thought about it for a whole day, and then at dinner he said, "Yeah. I want to see Uncle."

...

We met at the beach just south of town where the water's calm behind the reef. His idea. He said it was where he'd tried to teach his son to swim. He said he didn't know if that was a good reason or a bad one.

I saw him before he saw us. He was sitting on the sand above the waterline with his knees pulled up, the way a kid sits, looking at the water. Thinner than in the gym. Gray at the sides of his head, more than a year's worth. A sunburn already on the back of his neck. He had the look of a man who's carried something heavy for a long way and put it down and doesn't know what to do with his arms.

Keola let go of my hand and walked down the beach toward him, ahead of me. Not running. Walking. He stopped in front of him.

"Hi, Uncle."

The man looked up. I saw his face do what I knew it would. I saw him see my son, alive, nine, brown, standing in the sun with his new crooked teeth. I saw him see the other boy who wasn't there.

"Hi," he said. "Hi, Keola."

He knew the name now. I'd told him in my first letter. He said it carefully, every sound in its place, the way you'd pick up something that might break.

...

We sat on the sand, the three of us, in a row, and watched the water for a while. A sea turtle came in, a big one, and put its old face up and breathed out, *pff*, like a tired man sitting down, and went on.

"That's the same turtle," Wes said.

"How you know?" said Keola.

"I don't. It just feels like it."

"Could be," Keola said seriously. "They live like a hundred years."

. . .

When Keola went down to the water's edge to look for shells, Wes and I talked.

I'm not going to tell you all of it. Some of it was ours. I'll tell you this.

He told me he had read every word I'd written him a hundred times. He told me he still woke up at three in the morning. He told me he coached his swimmers and couldn't get in the pool. He told me his wife had gone into the water that night, from the torn bag, at the bottom of the wall. The same night. The same water as his son. He said it very plainly, looking at the sea. He said, "So she got her wish. She's somewhere warm."

I told him about my mother. About the bank, and the pencil in her hair, and the plastic chair on the lanai, and how she hollered at Bully about the news for forty years. I told him she'd never been past her knees in the ocean in her whole life. Seventy-nine years on an island and she never went past her knees.

"She told me that," he said. "On the wall."

"She said something else to you," I said. "On the wall. Keola told me. I wrote it to you."

"Take my life."

"You know what it means now."

"I know what it means." He was quiet for a long time. Then he said the thing I think he'd come all the way from Ohio to say.

"I didn't take it. That's the thing. She gave him to me, and told me to hold him, whatever, and I didn't. I lost him. In the dark. I lost both of them. And then I grabbed the first one that came. I didn't take her life. I took whatever bumped into me. If it had been Theo who bumped into me, I'd have held Theo all night, and told myself your boy was fine because he could swim, and he'd have been fine, maybe, he swam to me, didn't he, he'd have swum to somebody. Or he wouldn't. I don't know. I don't *know*. I didn't choose. That's what I can't stand. I didn't save your son. I just didn't let go of him."

The water came in and went out.

"Wes," I said. I'd never said his name out loud before. "That's what she asked you to do."

He looked at me.

"She didn't say *save him*. She didn't say *choose*. She was seventy-nine years old and smart as anything, she knew nobody can promise to save anybody in a fire. She said *hold him. Don't let go. Whatever.*" I put my hand flat on the sand between us. "You didn't let go. All night. With smoke in your head. With your own boy gone. You held on to a stranger's kid and you didn't let go. That's what she asked. You did it."

"I did it to the wrong boy."

"There was no wrong boy." I didn't know I was going to say it until I said it, and it came out harder than I meant, and I didn't take it back. "There was two boys and one man and the whole sea. There was no wrong boy. There was two boys and you couldn't hold them both, and nobody could, and *you know that*, you know it better than me, you're a coach, you know what a person can hold in the water. You held one. That's what a person can do. Don't you dare call my son the wrong boy."

He put his face in his hands. I let him.

Down at the water Keola had found something and was holding it up to the light, turning it, a shell or a piece of old glass, and he looked up the beach at us to see if we'd seen. I lifted my hand so he'd know I had. That's most of being a mother, most days. Lifting your hand so they know you saw. I sat next to this man who had nobody left to lift his hand for, and I didn't touch him, and I didn't leave.

After a while I said, quieter, "I'm still angry at you. I want you to know that. Not much. A little. Some nights. I'm angry that you held him and not my mother. I know that doesn't make sense. She was on the wall. She wouldn't go in. I'm angry anyway."

"Okay," he said into his hands.

"And I'm angry that you came here. Tourists. All of you. I clean your rooms. I'm angry about your pineapple cookie jar, the one you told

me about, and your sunset photos and the apartment you rented that used to be somebody's house. I'm angry that the town has to have you, to live. I'm angry that we need your five dollars on the pillow."

"Okay."

"And I'm so grateful to you I could die from it. I'm grateful to you every day. Every single day, when he wakes up, I think: that haole held him. I think it when I look at him. I'll think it every day of my life."

He took his hands off his face. He nodded. He didn't say anything. There wasn't anything to say. We sat there next to each other on the sand, angry and grateful and sorry, all of it real, none of it canceling anything out, and looked at the water, where my son was standing up to his knees, looking for shells.

. . .

"He wants to teach you something," I said, finally. "He's been planning it for a month. He told me not to tell you."

"Teach me what?"

I didn't answer. I just called down the beach: "Keola! Uncle's ready!"

And my son turned around in the water, with a shell in each hand, and grinned at us with his big crooked new teeth, and it was the grin from before. From the harbor wall. I hadn't seen it in a year.

26. Ears In

Wes

He took me by the hand, which nobody had done in a year, and he walked me down into the water.

It was warm. That was the first thing. Warm as a bath, the way it had been on the first day, before. Clear as gin over white sand, little yellow fish nosing at my ankles. I stood in it up to my knees and I felt it in the backs of my legs, that old high-board feeling, *I can't see what's under it*, and I stopped.

He felt me stop. He didn't pull. He just stood there next to me, holding my hand, nine years old, looking up at me.

"It's okay, Uncle," he said. "We go slow."

We went slow. Knees. Thighs. Waist. The water moving round me, lifting a little, setting down, lifting. I hadn't been in water deeper than a shower in a year. My heart was going like a bird's. Keola walked next to me with his hand in mine and told me things, chattering, the way kids do when they're nervous and want you not to be. He told me the yellow fish were called *lau'ipala* [lah-oo-ee-PAH-lah]. He told me the turtle's name was *honu* [HOH-noo]. He told me *kai* [KYE] means the sea. I stopped walking for a second when he said that, and he waited. He told me his Tūtū used to bring him to the harbor when he was two and hold him in the water by the boat ramp.

When the water was up to my chest he stopped.

"Okay," he said. "Now you float."

I laughed. It came out wrong. "Keola, I know how to float. I teach floating. I've taught a thousand kids to float."

"I know," he said. "But you forgot."

...

I want to tell you about the next minute, and I want to tell it simply.

He stood next to me and put one small hand flat under the middle of my back. Exactly where I put mine, for a kid. Exactly where I'd put mine, all that night, under his.

"Lie back, Uncle," he said. "Arms out. Chin up. Ears in."

I lay back.

"Give it your weight," he said. "All of it. Tūtū said give the water your weight, it gives it back. Tūtū said the water knows you by name."

My words. Her words. The same words, from two ends of the world.

I gave it my weight.

I don't know how to tell you what that was like, after a year. It was like putting down a suitcase you've carried so long you've forgotten

it's in your hand. The water came up round my ears and closed over them, and the world went away. The beach, the voices, the wind, the sound of my own breathing, all of it went far off and soft, and there was only the inside sound of the sea, the click and hiss and hum of it, the sound I'd loved my whole life, the sound of being held. Above me the sky was huge and blue and coming down to meet me. The small hand under my back was steady.

And then it wasn't there.

He'd taken it away. Slowly, the way I take mine away, so gently a kid doesn't know when it happens. And I was floating. On my own. My arms out, my face to the sky, the sea holding me up as if I weighed nothing, as if I weighed exactly as much as I should.

I knew the trick. I've done it to a thousand children. I knew exactly what he was doing, and I let him do it to me anyway, the way you let a child pay for lunch with the money you gave him. And the sea did what it does. It took the weight his hand had been holding and held it instead, all of it, without making anything of it, and gave it back to me as lift.

. . .

And then, under the water, in my ears, I heard something.

I'll tell you what I heard, and you'll think what you think.

I heard, very far off, the way you hear a radio playing in a house down the street, a woman singing. Slow. Old words. Up and down, like the waves. A voice used to carrying.

And under it, closer, very soft, so soft I could hardly be sure, a voice I knew. A boy's voice. Counting.

One. Two. Three. Here it comes. Hold.

My own count. In his voice. Calm. Not afraid. Not afraid at all. Counting the waves, the way I'd counted them all that night for both boys, out loud, so they could hear me.

Four. Five. Breathe.

. . .

I lay on the water with my ears under and my eyes full and I didn't move, because I knew that if I moved it would stop. I let it go on. I let the water hold me up, and I listened, and I didn't count anything. For the first time in a year, I let someone else do the counting.

I don't know how long. When I came up, Keola was standing a few feet away, up to his chest, watching me, the way he must have watched me that night, from the strap of my bag. Keeping an eye on me. His mother was on the beach, standing at the water's edge with her arms folded, crying, and pretending not to.

"See?" Keola said. "You remember."

"Yeah," I said. "I remember."

"Tūtū said it knows you by name."

"I know," I said. "I heard."

Said to You

I've been talking to you all night. You know that now.

Not to them. Not to the people on the shore, or the man from Ohio, or the woman who cleans the rooms. Not to the boy with the new crooked teeth. To you.

You came down to me a little after the dark came. You remember. The car went up on the street, and the wave came in at the same moment, and your father's arms opened, and you went under. You went under with your eyes shut and your mouth shut tight, and you couldn't tell which way was up, and you kicked, and you came up in the smoke, and you couldn't see anything. Not the wall. Not your father. Not the other boy. Only red dark, and smoke, and me. Deep me. No floor.

You called for your father. *Dad. Dad.* He was very close. He was calling for you too. You couldn't hear each other over me, over the wind and the fire and the people. I'm sorry. I'm sorry for that most of all, out of everything. You were so close.

And then the next wave came, and you went down again, and this time you didn't come up.

I want you to know what happened then, because you were frightened, and I don't want you to be frightened anymore.

You were afraid of me all your life. You told your father once that you couldn't see what was under me. That's what you were most afraid of: the not seeing. The place where the floor goes away. And then there you were, in the place where the floor goes away, in the dark, the thing you were most afraid of in the world.

So I held you.

I'm not good at gentleness. I told you that at the start. But I was gentle with you. I held you the way your father holds a child in the water, flat, with one hand under the small of the back, so you could feel that something had you. I held you so you wouldn't hit the rocks. I held you so the waves wouldn't throw you. And I talked to you. I've been talking to you ever since. I told you where you were. I told you about the reef and the islands and the rain. I told you about the streams that used to run through this town and the king on his island in the pond. I told you how I lost my floor too, how they turned me away from my own town. I told you what they'll do up there, after. I told you everything I know, the way you'd tell a child a story in the dark so he'll stop being afraid of it. The old woman on the hill told her grandson stories every night. I learned it from her.

And then your mother came.

You didn't know that. Your father didn't know it either, not then. When the car went up and the wave took you, it tore your father's bag on the rocks. And she came out. All of her that was left. Fine and pale and soft as flour, she came out into me and spread out through the water all around the wall, all around you, and I carried her to you. I wrapped you in her. She was all around you, in the dark, in the warm. She was right there. She'd wanted to come into the sea at Lahaina, from a boat, in the channel, where the whales sing, and instead she came in at the bottom of a wall in a burning town, at the very same moment as her son. I don't think she minded. I think that's where she'd have chosen, if she'd known. Next to you.

So you weren't alone. You were never alone. Not for one second of it.

And then the singing came down.

The old woman on the wall, the one who'd given her grandson to your father, sat up there above you with her feet hanging over me, and she began to sing. She was singing down into the water, to her boy. She couldn't see him. She didn't know which boy was where. Nobody did. So she sang down into me to whoever was there, and I carried it, every word, down to where you were, and you heard it. A song about this place. About shade and water and rain in the night. You didn't know the words. You didn't need them.

And somewhere in the middle of it, in the middle of the song, with your mother all around you and the old woman's voice coming down through the water, you stopped being afraid.

I felt it. You went soft. Your arms opened. You lay back in me, and put your ears in, and gave me your weight.

You floated.

Your father always wanted to see that. He tried for two years. He brought you all the way across the world to see it. He saw the other boy do it, up near the wall, in the smoke, and he cried and said your mother's name and said, *look, he's floating*. He was wrong about which boy. He wasn't wrong about the floating. You both did. One near the wall in a stranger's arms. One out here with me. Both of you, that same night, in the same water, for the first time, not afraid.

...

That was a year ago, they say up there. Up there they count everything. For me it's still that night. For me it's always that night. Water doesn't keep time. It keeps everything else.

Your father came back today. You know that. You were there. He lay down on me with his ears under, the first time in a year, with the other boy's hand under his back and then not, and he gave me his weight, all of it, the whole year of it. I gave it back. That's all I've ever been able to do. Hold things up. Give back what's given. Bring things home.

He heard you. I let him. Just for a minute. Just your voice, counting, the way he taught you. He'll never know if it was real. That's all right. He doesn't need to know. He only needs to have heard it.

I won't give you back to him. I'm sorry. I can't. Nothing that comes all the way down to me goes back up the old way. But I'll tell you what I've told every child of this town for a thousand years, and what the old woman told her grandson every night, on the hill, in the house that isn't there:

Everything that comes down to me, I keep. Every drop. Every tear. Every boy. Nothing is lost here. Only mixed.

Your mother's here. The old woman's song is here. The streams that used to run through the town are here, the water from the king's pond, the rain that fell on this island the day it rose. All of it. All of you. In the warm. In the deep part. Where you can't see what's under it, because there's nothing under it now but me.

Lie still. You're all right.

I've got you. I've got you both.

GLOSSARY

ahupua‘a [ah-hoo-poo-AH-ah] — Hawaiian, *land division*. A slice of land running from the mountaintop to the sea, following a stream, so that every family in it had forest, water, farmland and fish.

aloha [ah-LOH-hah] — Hawaiian, *love, hello, goodbye*. The everyday Hawaiian greeting, carrying all three meanings at once.

brah [BRAH] — Hawai‘i Pidgin, *brother*. A friendly word for any man.

haole [HOW-leh] — Hawaiian, *foreigner*. Used in Hawai‘i for white people; it can be rude, or simply a description.

honu [HOH-noo] — Hawaiian, *green sea turtle*.

Kā‘anapali [kah-AH-nah-PAH-lee] — A stretch of beach and resorts a few miles up the coast from Lahaina.

kai [KYE] — Hawaiian, *the sea*.

Ka malu ‘ulu o Lele [kah MAH-loo OO-loo oh LEH-leh] — Hawaiian, *the shade of the breadfruit trees of Lele*. An old saying for the town of Lahaina.

kālua [KAH-loo-ah] — Hawaiian, *to bake underground*. Pork cooked slowly in a pit oven.

Kamehameha [kah-MAY-hah-MAY-hah] — The name of the kings of Hawai‘i. The third Kamehameha lived on the island of Moku‘ula in Lahaina.

Kanoe [kah-NOH-eh] — Hawaiian, *the mist*. The narrator’s name.

Kaua‘ula [kow-ah-OO-lah] — A valley and stream behind Lahaina, and the place where the 2018 fire began.

keiki [KAY-kee] — Hawaiian, *child, children*.

Keola [keh-OH-lah] — Hawaiian, *the life*. Kanoe’s son.

kuleana [koo-leh-AH-nah] — Hawaiian, *responsibility, and the right that comes with it*. The duty to care for something, together with the right to belong to it.

Kula [KOO-lah] — An upcountry district on the slopes of Maui's big mountain, where another fire burned the same night.

Lahaina [lah-HY-nah] — Hawaiian, often translated *cruel sun*. The old royal capital on the west coast of Maui.

Lahainaluna [lah-HY-nah-LOO-nah] — Hawaiian, *upper Lahaina*. The road and the old high school on the slope above the town, where the fire began.

lanai [lah-NYE] — Hawaiian, *porch*. A covered porch or balcony.

Lānaʻi [lah-NAH-ee] — The island across the channel from Lahaina.

lauʻipala [lah-oo-ee-PAH-lah] — Hawaiian, *yellow tang*. A small, bright yellow reef fish.

lei [LAY] — Hawaiian, *garland*. A necklace of flowers.

Lele [LEH-leh] — Hawaiian. The old name of Lahaina, when it was green and full of water.

li hing [LEE hing] — Chinese, *traveling plum*. A dried plum, sweet, sour and salty at once.

mahalo [mah-HAH-loh] — Hawaiian, *thank you*.

makai [mah-KYE] — Hawaiian, *toward the sea*. Used in place of a compass direction.

Maui [MOW-ee] — The Hawaiian island on which Lahaina stands.

mauka [MOW-kah] — Hawaiian, *toward the mountain*. Used in place of a compass direction.

Mauna Kahālāwai [MOW-nah kah-HAH-lah-WHY] — Hawaiian, *the mountain where the waters meet*. The West Maui mountain behind Lahaina.

mele [MEH-leh] — Hawaiian, *song, chant*. A Hawaiian song, often a song for a place.

Mokuhinia [moh-koo-hee-NEE-ah] — The spring-fed royal pond in the middle of Lahaina, filled in early in the last century.

Moku'ula [moh-koo-OO-lah] — Hawaiian, *sacred island*. The small island in the royal pond where the king lived. It lies under a ballpark today.

Moloka'i [moh-loh-KAH-ee] — The long island to the north of Lāna'i, across the channel.

mu'umu'u [MOO-oo MOO-oo] — Hawaiian, *a loose gown*. A long, loose flowered dress.

musubi [moo-SOO-bee] — Japanese, *to tie together*. A block of rice with a slice of fried Spam on top, wrapped in seaweed.

nānā honua [NAH-nah hoh-NOO-ah] — Hawaiian, *earth-gazing*. The angel's trumpet, a tree with long hanging flowers that point at the ground. It was brought to Hawai'i from elsewhere, and every part of it is poisonous.

poi [POY] — Hawaiian. A soft purple paste made from pounded taro root.

taro [TAH-roh] — from Tahitian, *the taro plant*. A root grown in flooded ponds, the old staple food of Hawai'i.

Tūtū [TOO-too] — Hawaiian, *grandma*. What everyone calls Kanoe's mother.

wai [WHY] — Hawaiian, *fresh water*.

Wailuku [why-LOO-koo] — The county town on the other side of Maui, where the hospital is.

waiwai [why-WHY] — Hawaiian, *wealth*. Literally *water, water*.

Lahaina was once called Lele. It was so full of running water that the whalers called it the Venice of the Pacific. Then the sugar planters turned the streams away to their fields. Now the hills above the town are dry grass, and nobody cuts it.

Kanoe cleans hotel rooms up the coast. Her mother has never gone into the sea past her knees. Her son backflips off the harbor wall every afternoon.

Wes coaches swimming in Ohio. He has brought his nine-year-old son to Maui, and his wife's ashes in a backpack, to give her to the sea where they were married. He has taught a thousand children to swim. His own son will not put his face in the water.

It is August 2023. A hurricane passes far to the south. A power line comes down in the wind. By mid-morning, the fire is declared contained.

All night, something under the seawall is talking to someone.



Whatever you take, let some of it get home.